

Please note that the provided sources do not explicitly contain expositions on **Amos suggesting the Sabbath will come to an end (af-076), Galatians 4:9-11 (af-084), John 20:19 and the disciples instituting Sunday-keeping (af-109), 1 Corinthians 16:1, 2 regarding Sunday offerings (af-114), Romans 14:5 (af-145), or the specific day of the week of Pentecost (af-217)**. You may want to independently verify the biblical explanations for those specific texts outside of these sources. Here is the comprehensive information on the other topics covered in your query:

Is it necessary to go to church on the Sabbath?

(af-037)Yes, the sources explicitly teach that believers should assemble for worship. While the Sabbath should not be spent shut within walls listening to overly long, tedious sermons, **it is necessary that the people of God assemble to talk of Him, to interchange thoughts, and to pray** (*Testimonies for the Church, vol. 2, "How Shall We keep the Sabbath?"*). Parents are instructed to "make it a rule that their children attend public worship on the Sabbath, and should enforce the rule by their own example" (*Child Guidance, "Sabbath—The Day of Delight"*).

Is keeping the seventh-day Sabbath necessary for salvation? (af-069)

Yes, depending on the light a person has received. The texts state plainly: **"It means eternal salvation to keep the Sabbath holy unto the Lord"** (*Counsels for the Church, "The Observance of God's Holy Sabbath"*). However, God judges people according to their understanding. "If they have light upon the Sabbath, they cannot be saved in rejecting that light. But none will be held accountable for light which they have never received" (*Historical Sketches of Foreign Missions, "An Interruption"*).

Did the disciples keep Sunday as a holy day?

(af-115)No. The sources assert that the apostles did not observe Sunday or command its observance. Protestants themselves acknowledge that **"up to the time of Christ's death, no change had been made in the day; and, so far as the record shows, they the apostles did not give**

any explicit command enjoining the abandonment of the seventh-day Sabbath, and its observance on the first day of the week" (*The Great Controversy 1888*, "God's Law Immutable"). The observance of Sunday had its origin in the "mystery of lawlessness" which began its work in the early centuries, not in the teachings or practices of Christ or His disciples.

Isn't the Sabbath for the Jews only? (af-117)"The Sabbath was not for Israel merely, but for the world" (*The Desire of Ages*, "The Sabbath"). It was instituted in Eden before the fall of man, and was committed to Adam as the father and representative of the whole human family. The institution was "wholly commemorative, and given to all mankind. There was nothing in it shadowy or of restricted application to any people" (*Patriarchs and Prophets*, "The Creation").

Why were the Ten Commandments put on two tablets instead of just one? (af-168)The Decalogue was divided onto two tables to reflect its two core principles. **The first four commandments were given to show men their duty to God**, with the fourth commandment (the Sabbath) serving as the connecting link between the great God and man. **The last six precepts show the duty of man to his fellow man** (*The Story of Redemption*, "The Law Given to Israel").

How did the Israelites know how to behave before the Ten Commandments were given? (af-195)The law of God existed long before it was spoken at Mount Sinai. **"After Adam and Eve were created, God made known to them His law. It was not then written, but was rehearsed to them by Jehovah"** (*The Story of Redemption*, "God's Eternal Law"). These principles were passed down through the generations. The sources note that if the descendants of Abraham had faithfully kept the covenant, "there would have been no necessity for God's law to be proclaimed from Sinai or engraved upon tables of stone" (*From Eternity Past*, "The Sin of Nadab and Abihu").

Wasn't the old covenant the Ten Commandments? (af-205)**The Ten Commandments were the basis of the covenant the Lord made with His people.** However, "the covenant itself was the Lord's promise to write the law in

their hearts... so that it would be their joy to obey" (*From Eternity Past*, "Appendix").

Which day is the Sabbath and does it still matter

today? (af-218) God has expressly designated **the seventh day (Saturday) as His Sabbath**, a day of 24 hours marked off by the rising and setting of the sun (*SDA Bible Commentary*, vol. 7, "Chapter 14"; *Testimonies to Ministers and Gospel Workers*, "God's High Standard"). It absolutely matters today. The Sabbath is the "great test of loyalty" and the "sign of obedience" that distinguishes God's true followers from the rest of the world (*The Great Controversy*, "The Final Warning"). In the last days, the Sabbath will be the central issue in the great conflict between the commandments of God and the requirements of men.

Are some types of work permissible on Sabbath, such as nursing? (af-220) Yes. **"Acts of necessity and mercy are permitted on the Sabbath; the sick and suffering are at all times to be cared for"** (*Patriarchs and Prophets*, "The Law and the Covenants"). The sources explicitly state that physicians and nurses are often called upon to minister to the sick on the Sabbath, and "the labor required to make them comfortable is a work of necessity, and no violation of the Sabbath" (*Historical Sketches of Foreign Missions*, "Importance of the Sabbath"). However, all *unnecessary* work, ordinary treatments, and operations that can wait must be strictly avoided (*Medical Ministry*, "The Physician Not Exempt").

Does the New Testament replace the Ten

Commandments with a new law of love? (af-281) No.

The claim that Christ abolished His Father's law by His death is entirely without foundation (*True Revival*, "Can God's Law Be Changed?"). The New Testament gospel of grace and love does not replace the Ten Commandments; it establishes them. **"The great principles of love to God, which He set forth as the foundation of the law and the prophets, are only a reiteration of what He had spoken through Moses... The teacher is the same in both dispensations"** (*Patriarchs and Prophets*, "The Law and the Covenants"). The law of Jehovah and the gospel go hand in hand; "the law of Jehovah is the tree, the gospel is

the fragrant blossoms and fruit which it bears" (*SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, "Chapter 3"*).

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here is a comprehensive response to your questions regarding law, grace, and the commandments:

Willful Sin and the Unpardonable (af-023)

Hebrews 10:26 warns that if we sin willfully after receiving the truth, there remains no more sacrifice for sins. The sources illustrate this using the Old Testament cities of refuge. The prisoner who went outside the city limits was abandoned to the avenger of blood. "Thus the people were taught to adhere to the methods which infinite wisdom appointed for their security. Even so, it is not enough that the sinner believe in Christ for the pardon of sin; he must, by faith and obedience, abide in Him" (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Cities of Refuge"). If a person deliberately and persistently rebels, refusing to abide in Christ's provided security, they abandon the only sacrifice that can save them.

Does God Harden Hearts or Punish for Ancestors'

Sins? (af-030, af-047, af-057) God does not arbitrarily harden people's hearts. As established in our conversation history, the hardening of the heart is the natural result of human choice. When a person resists the Holy Spirit, that first resistance prepares the way for a second resistance, and "thus the heart is hardened" (Character Sketches From the Life of Daniel, "Nebuchadnezzar's Humiliation"). Regarding the punishment for the sins of ancestors, children are not punished for their parents' guilt unless they willingly participate in those same sins (From Eternity Past, "God Gives His Law on Mount Sinai"). The generation that Jesus denounced in His day was not responsible for the sins of their fathers, "only so far as they followed their evil practices" (*SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, Comments on Matthew 19:41-44*). However, while guilt is not transferred, consequences and tendencies are. Because of Adam's fall, "wrong tendencies, perverted appetites, and debased morals, as well as physical disease and degeneracy, are transmitted as a legacy from father to son" (From Eternity Past, "God Gives His Law on Mount Sinai"). *Note:*

The sources do not specifically dissect the theology of an infant committing a sin, but they clarify that humanity inherits these fallen propensities and weaknesses from Adam, while remaining accountable only for their own willful choices.

Are Christians Incapable of Sinning? (af-070) Christians are entirely capable of committing sin, and the idea of absolute sinless perfection in the flesh is condemned. "The claim to be without sin is evidence that he who makes this claim is far from holy" and demonstrates that the person has no true conception of the infinite purity of God or the evil of sin (From Here to Forever, "How Successful Are Modern Revivals?"; The Sanctified Life, "The Testing Time").

Did Christ Fulfill, Abolish, or Put an End to the Law? (af-075, af-111, af-137) Jesus coming to "fulfill" the law does not mean He abolished it. "To fulfill means to keep, or perform.... To fulfill the law is to obey it perfectly" (The Story of Jesus, "Sabbathkeeping"). By obeying the law perfectly, Christ demonstrated that it is immutable; if the moral law could have been changed or set aside, He would not have needed to die to save man from its penalty (The Great Controversy 1888, "Modern Revivals"). Furthermore, the Bible does not teach that the Ten Commandments are faulty. The claim that the law spoken by God's own voice is faulty is a lie originating with Satan; it is the "last great deception that he will bring upon the world" (The Desire of Ages, "It is Finished"). *Please note that the sources do not explicitly provide an exegesis of Romans 10:4 ("Christ is the end of the law"), and you may want to independently verify that specific verse.* However, they emphasize continually that Christ's death was for the very purpose of magnifying the law and making it honorable, not putting an end to its binding claims (Faith and Works, "Man May Be As Pure in His Sphere As God Is in His").

Was the Law Nailed to the Cross? (af-086) The moral law of Ten Commandments was *not* nailed to the cross. The sources warn that it is a fatal error to blend the moral and ceremonial laws. The "ritual law, with its sacrifices and ordinances" which foreshadowed Christ was "nailed to His cross" because the types and shadows met their fulfillment in Christ's death (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Law and the

Covenants"). The moral law, however, remains as immutable as the throne of God.

The Origin of the Law and the "Schoolmaster" (af-085, af-091, af-092)The Ten Commandments existed long before Mount Sinai. The angels were governed by this law, and Satan fell because he transgressed it. After Adam and Eve were created, God made His law known to them, though it was not written on stone until Sinai (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "Law of God"). In Galatians 3, where Paul describes the law as a "schoolmaster" (or tutor) to bring us to Christ, he is referring to *both* the ceremonial and the moral code of ten commandments (Selected Messages Book 1, "The Law in Galatians"). The ceremonial system acted as a schoolmaster by constantly educating Israel about the intervention of Christ and His shedding of blood. Meanwhile, the moral law acts as a schoolmaster by functioning as a mirror: it reveals our sin and condemns us to punishment. Because the law has no power to pardon, it "drives us to Christ, who was hanged upon the cross that He might be able to impart His righteousness to fallen, sinful man" (Selected Messages Book 1, "The Law in Galatians").

Being "Dead" to the Law (af-139)When Paul writes about being "dead" to the law in order to live for God, he does not mean the law itself is dead or abolished. Relating his experience, Paul says, "I was alive without the law once... but when the commandment came, sin revived, and I died" (Romans 7:9). The texts instruct: "Mark, it was Paul, and not the law, that died" (The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 4, "Modern Revivals"). Sin killed the carnal mind in Paul, allowing him to be delivered from the condemnation of the law so he could "serve in newness of spirit, and not in the oldness of the letter" (Selected Messages Book 1, "The Perfect Law").

Old Testament Salvation (af-277)People in the Old Testament were not saved by keeping the law; they were saved by grace through faith in Christ, just as believers are today. "Every soul saved in the former dispensation was saved by Christ as verily as we are saved by Him today. Patriarchs and prophets were Christians" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, Comments on Acts 15:11). The gospel promise was given to Adam and Abraham, and the entire sacrificial system was centered on faith in the coming

Messiah (Selected Messages Book 1, "The Law and the Gospel").

Please note that the provided sources do not explicitly explain the meaning of **Rachel's "soul departing" (af-104), Revelation 6:9 regarding the souls under the altar (af-093)**, or provide a specific verse-by-verse exegesis of **Paul's desire to "depart and be with Christ" or be "absent from the body" (af-080, af-082)**, although his broader teachings on the resurrection are covered. You may want to independently verify those specific scriptures. Here is the comprehensive biblical and theological information from the sources regarding your other questions:

What Happens to the Spirit/Soul at Death? (af-004, af-062, af-143) The Bible does not teach that the body and soul are separate entities capable of conscious existence apart from one another. The belief in man's natural immortality was borrowed from pagan philosophy and incorporated into the Christian faith during the great apostasy (*The Great Controversy*, "Can Our Dead Speak to Us?"). The Scriptures declare, "The soul that sinneth, it shall die" (Ezekiel 18:20), proving that the soul is mortal and subject to death (*The Great Controversy*, "The First Great Deception"). When a person dies, they are not conscious. At death, the "spirit, the character of man, is returned to God, there to be preserved" until the resurrection (*SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6*, Comments on 1 Corinthians 15). This spirit does not maintain a separate, conscious existence; rather, the individual simply sleeps. As the Bible says, "His breath goeth forth, he returneth to his earth; in that very day his thoughts perish" (*The Great Controversy*, "The First Great Deception").

Did Jesus Descend to Hell or Go to Heaven When He Died? (af-140, af-061) When Jesus died, He did not descend to a fiery hell, nor did His soul instantly go to heaven. The sources state explicitly: "The spirit of Jesus slept in the tomb with His body, and did not wing its way to heaven, there to maintain a separate existence" (*The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 3*, "The Resurrection of Christ"). All that

comprised the life and intelligence of Jesus remained with His body in the sepulcher. Consequently, Jesus did not assure the thief on the cross that they would be in paradise that very Friday. Jesus Himself did not go to Paradise that day, for on Sunday morning He told Mary, "I am not yet ascended to My Father" (*The Desire of Ages*, "Calvary"). By placing the comma after the word "today," the true meaning of the promise becomes clear: "Verily I say unto thee today while I am dying upon the cross as a malefactor, thou shalt be with Me in Paradise" (*The Desire of Ages*, "Calvary").

The Rich Man and Lazarus (af-026) The story of the rich man and Lazarus is a parable and does not teach that we go directly to heaven or hell at death. Christ used the prevailing but unscriptural beliefs of His day to meet the people on their own ground and teach a crucial moral lesson: "that it is impossible for men to secure the salvation of the soul after death" (*Christ's Object Lessons*, "A Great Gulf Fixed"). The parable was meant to represent the hopelessness of looking for a second probation, emphasizing that this current life is the only time given to man to prepare for eternity.

"Passing from Death into Life" and "Never Seeing Death" (af-079, af-135) When Christians "pass from death unto life," it does not mean their souls go on living after their bodies die. Instead, this phrase describes the spiritual transformation of the new birth. When a sinner's heart is brought into harmony with God's law, "he has passed from death unto life, from transgression and rebellion to obedience and loyalty" (*The Great Controversy 1888*, "Modern Revivals"). Similarly, when Jesus said that a believer shall "never see death," He was speaking of the eternal second death. To the Christian, physical death "is but a small matter" and is viewed merely as a sleep—a moment of silence and darkness until Christ returns (*The Desire of Ages*, "The Lord Is Risen"). In dying, Jesus made it impossible for those who believe on Him to die eternally (*SDA Bible Commentary*, vol. 7A, Comments on John 11).

Eternal Torment, Unquenchable Fire, and the Undying Worm (af-045, af-051, af-054, af-112) Sinners are not going to be eternally tormented. The doctrine of an eternally burning hell is a heresy that maligns the character of God,

representing Him as a revengeful tyrant who delights in witnessing unceasing tortures (*The Great Controversy*, "The First Great Deception"). God's glory is not enhanced by perpetuating sin and suffering through ceaseless ages. Instead, the wicked will be entirely destroyed. The phrases regarding "unquenchable fire" and the "worm that dieth not" denote complete, inescapable destruction. The sources explain that the fire "shall not be quenched as long as there is the least particle for it to prey upon," and "the worm of life shall not die" until the consumption is complete (*Early Writings*, "The Second Death"). The wicked will be burned up "root and branch," suffering according to their deeds, but ultimately ending in the "second death," sinking into hopeless, eternal oblivion (*The Great Controversy*, "The First Great Deception"). Thus, God will make a clean universe where sin and sinners are no more.

Near-Death Experiences and Becoming Angels (af-225, af-287) People do not become angels when they die, and God does not speak to people through "near-death experiences" or encounters with the deceased. The Scriptures teach that angels existed before the creation of man, proving that they are a separate order of beings, not the disembodied spirits of dead men (*The Great Controversy*, "Agency of Evil Spirits"). Because the dead are completely unconscious, any manifestation of a deceased loved one is a demonic deception. Satan and his fallen angels have the power to assume the form of dead friends, reproduce their voices, and even state correct information to gain confidence, but this is the "masterpiece of deception" known as spiritualism (*The Truth About Angels*, "Angels in the Final Crisis"). Deceived mortals who think they are communicating with the dead are actually receiving dangerous errors from evil angels.

Capital Punishment (af-147) The Bible does support capital punishment for certain crimes in a theocratic context. Under the laws given to ancient Israel, if a person was proven guilty of murder, "no atonement or ransom could rescue him." The law stated, "Ye shall take no satisfaction for the life of a murderer, which is guilty of death: but he shall be surely put to death" (*From Eternity Past*, "The Cities

of Refuge"). The safety and purity of the nation demanded that the sin of murder be severely punished.

Please note that the provided sources do not contain information to explicitly answer your questions regarding **whether Satan's access to heaven is suggested in Job 1:6 (af-033), why Jesus said "let the dead bury their own dead" (af-056), Herod's decree to kill the babies (af-060), whether literal dogs will be in heaven (af-120), the meaning of binding on earth and heaven (af-127), Elijah praying for a boy (af-128), Isaiah 66:24 regarding the wicked burning (af-130), one day equaling a thousand years (af-141), or the exact dimensions and capacity of the holy city (af-151)**. You may want to independently verify biblical explanations for those specific topics.

Here is the comprehensive information addressing your other questions:

Will we recognize our loved ones in heaven?

(af-009)Yes. The resurrection perfectly preserves individual identity. The sources assure us that "we shall know our friends, as the disciples knew Jesus... in the glorified body their identity will be perfectly preserved. We shall recognize those we love" (From Heaven With Love, "The Walk to Emmaus"). Furthermore, "every saint connected in family relationship here will know each other there" (Last Day Events, "The Inheritance of the Saints").

What is the meaning of Ezekiel's valley of dry bones?

(af-010)Ezekiel's vision of the valley of dry bones represents those who are spiritually "dead in trespasses and sins." The bones coming together and receiving breath illustrate that "unless the vital breath of God quickens the soul to spiritual life," people merely have a form of religion without true conversion. It teaches that human power cannot impart spiritual life; only the breath of the Lord can quicken a lifeless spiritual nature into an exceeding great army for God (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 4, Chapter 37).

Does the Bible give guidelines on burying the dead? Is cremation okay? (af-014)

While "cremation" is not explicitly named, the theological principles in the sources

make it clear that the method of body disposal does not impact God's ability to resurrect a person. The texts explain that in the resurrection, "there is no law of God in nature which shows that God gives back the same identical particles of matter which composed the body before death" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, Chapter 15). Regarding funerals, the Bible records simple burials, noting that "God is not honored in the great display and extravagant expense incurred in returning bodies to the dust" (From Eternity Past, "Death of Moses").

Does Matthew 28:1 show that Christ rose from the dead on Saturday night? (af-050)No. The sources clearly state that Jesus rested in Joseph's tomb "through the sacred hours of the Sabbath day" and that "when holy beings of both Heaven and earth were astir on the morning of the first day of the week, he rose from the grave" (The Desire of Ages, "In Joseph's Tomb"; The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 3, "Women at the Tomb").

What does it mean that "flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God"? (af-108)This phrase from Paul means that "man in his present state is mortal, corruptible; but the kingdom of God will be incorruptible, enduring forever. Therefore man in his present state cannot enter into the kingdom of God" (The Great Controversy, "Heralds of the Morning"). Flesh and blood cannot enter until Jesus comes, changes our vile bodies, and "confers immortality upon His people" (The Great Controversy, "Heralds of the Morning").

Does Matthew teach that some commandment breakers will be in heaven? (af-125)No. The sources declare emphatically: "None who have had the light of truth will enter the city of God as commandment-breakers" (Faith and Works, "Appropriating the Righteousness of Christ"). God's law is the foundation of His government; those who knowingly trample upon it on earth will not be taken to heaven to rebel there, for "there is no change of character when Christ comes" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7, Chapter 22).

Doesn't the Bible teach that King David's house would be established forever? (af-126)The promise of David's eternal throne is fulfilled in Jesus Christ. After the successions of earthly empires, the throne of the Lord was

"removed from this world and will 'be no more, until He come whose right it is,' and then it will be given Him" (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Kingdom of God"). Christ will receive the throne of His father David and reign over His kingdom forever and ever in the earth made new.

Will our planet be the "new earth" after Jesus' second coming? (af-169)Yes. Following the millennium, the fire that consumes the wicked will purify this very earth, sweeping away every trace of the curse (The Great Controversy, "The Controversy Ended"). The earth originally given to Adam, and betrayed into the hands of Satan, is "brought back by the great plan of redemption... God's original purpose in the creation of the earth is fulfilled as it is made the eternal abode of the redeemed" (The Great Controversy, "The Controversy Ended").

In heaven, will we have memories of everything about our life on this earth? (af-172)We will have memories, but without the pain. Memory will be utilized so we can understand God's saving grace: "All that has perplexed us in the providences of God will in the world to come be made plain," and we will converse with our guardian angels to learn the history of divine interposition in our lives (The Great Controversy, "God's People Delivered"; Education, "The School of the Hereafter"). However, the agony of our past will not burden us: "Do you think anyone there will take time to tell of his trials and terrible difficulties? 'The former shall not be remembered, nor come into mind'" (Selected Messages Book 3, "Questions About the Saved").

Will non-Christians who live a good life receive less punishment or possibly be saved? (af-173)Some who never officially knew Christ will be saved. "Among the heathen are those who worship God ignorantly, those to whom the light is never brought by human instrumentality, yet they will not perish" (Heaven, "Who Will Be There?"). Because they heard God's voice speaking to them in nature and cherished a spirit of kindness, their works evidence that the Holy Spirit touched their hearts, and they are accepted (Heaven, "Who Will Be There?"). God does not condemn anyone for not heeding light they never had and could not obtain (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, Chapter 15).

Did the "war in heaven" take place before or after the

time of Adam and Eve? (af-174)The rebellion and war in heaven took place *before* the fall of Adam and Eve. Angels were created before humanity, and when Adam and Eve were placed in Eden, they were explicitly "warned against this dangerous foe" who had already fallen and was attempting to usurp God's authority (The Great Hope, "Everlasting Life").

Some say that when we're in heaven, we'll be wearing robes of light. Is this biblical? (af-194)Yes. The redeemed will be clothed with "garments of praise and thanksgiving—the robe of Christ's righteousness" (The Ministry of Healing, "Help for the Unemployed and the Homeless"). They will wear "robes woven in the loom of heaven with not one thread of humanity in them" and stand before the throne clad in richer apparel than earthly monarchs have ever worn (Temperance, "Appendix B"; The Great Controversy, "God's People Delivered").

Will the wicked be able to see the righteous who are inside the New Jerusalem? (af-236)Yes. At the end of the millennium, when the wicked surround the Holy City, Jesus and His loyal subjects will ascend to the top of the walls. "The wicked host behold the splendor of the city, and the happy redeemed company upon its walls, and are amazed at the scene" (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "After the Flood"). Seeing the radiant glory of the saved and the majesty of Christ, the courage of the wicked fails, and they wail in anguish for the eternal life they threw away (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "After the Flood").

How will the destruction of wicked angels and people affect God? (af-238)God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked (From Here to Forever, "What Lies Beyond the Grave?"). The destruction of the lost is an act of justice, but also of supreme mercy to both the universe and the wicked themselves. A life of rebellion unfits the wicked for heaven; its purity and holiness would be "torture to them," and they would actually "welcome destruction, that they might be hidden from the face of Him who died to redeem them" (The Great Controversy, "First Great Deception").

Will babies who die be saved in God's kingdom? (af-267)Yes. At the resurrection, "little children are borne by holy angels to their mothers' arms" (The Great

Controversy, "God's People Delivered"). For those who have no mother there, "the angels receive the motherless infants and conduct them to the tree of life" (The Truth About Angels, "Angels in the Final Crisis").

How can we know that the struggles and sacrifices in this life are really worth it? (af-268)The sources affirm that when the redeemed see the glories of heaven, they will cry out, "Alleluia! heaven is cheap enough!" (Heaven, "A Heavenly Atmosphere"). In His presence, all the trials and sufferings of this life will be viewed "as nothingness," and believers will realize that whatever crosses they were called to bear, they are "amply recompensed" by an eternal weight of glory (Counsels for the Church, "Behold, I Come Quickly"; Christ's Object Lessons, "To Meet the Bridegroom").

Is heaven a misty place with souls who only play harps and float on clouds? (af-269)Absolutely not. The texts warn that a "fear of making the future inheritance seem too material has led many to spiritualize away the very truths which lead us to look upon it as our home" (The Great Controversy, "The Controversy Ended"). Heaven is not a place of "sinful indolence" or "idle repose"; rather, it is a place of "interested activity" and loving service (Child Guidance, "Sabbath-The Day of Delight"; SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 3, Chapter 147). In the new earth, the redeemed will build literal houses, plant vineyards, explore the universe, and continue to develop every capability of mind and body (The Great Controversy, "The Controversy Ended").

Please note that the provided sources do not explicitly detail Paul's meaning of being "caught up to the third heaven" or "out of the body" (af-031), who the "sons of God" in Genesis 6 are (af-032), why John the Baptist denied being Elijah in his dialogue with the Jewish leaders (af-098), or the specific meaning of 1 Samuel 16:14 regarding an evil spirit coming from the Lord (af-138). You may want to independently verify these specific biblical questions.

Here is the comprehensive information addressing your other questions:

Is it possible for the devil to repent? (af-024)No, true

saving repentance is impossible for him. After Satan was cast out of heaven, he and his followers did weep and implore to be reinstated in God's favor. However, their sin of hatred, envy, and jealousy "had been so great that God could not blot it out" (Early Writings, "The Fall of Satan"). Because "sin originated with him, and the seeds of rebellion were within him," heaven would be placed in constant jeopardy if he were taken back (Early Writings, "The Fall of Satan"). The rebellious angels had "learned the lesson of genuine rebellion against the unchangeable law of God, and this is incurable" (The Story of Redemption, "Fall of Lucifer").

Did the witch of Endor really conjure up the spirit of Samuel the prophet? (af-028)No. God does not give Satan the power to resurrect the dead, nor did He allow Satan to disturb the rest of Samuel in the grave. Instead, "**Satan's angels assume the form of dead friends, and speak and act like them**" to carry on the work of deception (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 4a, "Samuel and Saul"). The apparition of Samuel was a demonic counterfeit, and its message was designed not to lead Saul to repentance, but to "goad him to despair and ruin" (Patriarchs and Prophets, "Ancient and Modern Sorcery").

Who is Michael the Archangel? (af-035)Michael the Archangel is Jesus Christ. He is the Son of God and "the Captain of the Lord's host" (Patriarchs and Prophets, "Appendix Note 8"). The sources reveal that it was Christ (Michael) who came to Gabriel's aid to influence the kings of Persia, and it was Christ who resurrected Moses and "meekly referred Satan to His Father, saying, 'The Lord rebuke thee'" (The Truth About Angels, "Angels From the Captivity to John the Baptist"; The Story of Redemption, "Death of Moses").

With whom did Jacob wrestle by the brook—an angel or God? (af-040)Jacob wrestled with Jesus Christ. "**It was Christ, 'the Angel of the covenant,' who had revealed Himself to Jacob**" (The Truth About Angels, "Angels in the Patriarchal Age"). While Hosea calls Him the angel and He appeared in the form of a man, Jacob correctly declared, "I have seen God face to face," because he was wrestling with the Majesty of heaven (The Truth About Angels, "Angels in the Patriarchal Age").

Will Elijah come back before Jesus returns? / What is the "spirit of Elijah"? (af-059, af-097)

The biblical promise of Elijah does not mean the literal prophet will return to earth, but rather refers to the **"spirit and power of Elias."** John the Baptist fulfilled this by going before Christ's first advent to turn the hearts of Israel to the Lord (The Truth About Angels, "Angels in the Time of Esther"). Prophecy also has a modern fulfillment: **"The present age is one of idolatry, as verily as was that in which Elijah lived... Today, as in the days of Elijah, the line of demarcation between God's commandment-keeping people and the worshipers of false gods is clearly drawn"** (Prophets and Kings, "In the Spirit and Power of Elias"). The modern message calling people out of spiritual Babylon is given in this same spirit and power.

Doesn't the scapegoat being our sin-bearer make him our savior? (af-099)No. The scapegoat typifies Satan, but this does not make him a savior or an atoning sacrifice. Christ's blood alone satisfies the broken law and atones for sin (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7, Comments on Revelation 12). However, just as the ancient high priest removed the forgiven sins from the sanctuary and placed them upon the live goat, Christ will ultimately place the guilt of all pardoned sins upon Satan, who is **"the author of sin"** (The Great Controversy 1888, "The Sanctuary"). Satan "is made to suffer not only for his own rebellion, but for all the sins which he has caused God's people to commit," and he will bear the final penalty of eternal destruction (From Here to Forever, "The Controversy Ended").

What does the symbolism of "frogs" mean in Revelation? (af-105)The "three unclean spirits like frogs" represent **"the spirits of devils, working miracles, which go forth unto the kings of the earth and of the whole world"** (The Great Hope, "False Hope"). This points to the final, worldwide deception of spiritualism, where Satan and his fallen angels will gather the nations to the great battle of Armageddon (Selected Messages Book 3, "Lessons From Meeting the Sunday Law Crisis").

How to handle temptation and "put on" the armor of God (af-152, af-188)To handle temptation, you must follow Christ's example in the wilderness by relying entirely on the

Word of God, meeting every attack with **"It is written"** (From Heaven With Love, "The Victory"). You must refuse to argue or parley with the enemy. Putting on the whole armor of God means engaging in constant vigilance and prayer. "Our finite will must be brought into submission to the will of the Infinite," bringing the Holy Spirit to our aid (Messages to Young People, "The Character of the Conflict"). Furthermore, **"the earnest prayer of faith will baffle his strongest efforts,"** causing the hosts of Satan to tremble and fall back (Prayer, "Satan and Prayer").

Does the Bible portray the devil as a red, beast-like creature with horns? (af-235)No. Satan is **"pleased to be painted as ludicrous, misshapen, half animal and half human"** because it causes people to mock the idea of his existence, leaving them entirely unguarded against his subtle deceptions (From Here to Forever, "Evil Spirits"). In reality, he is "a mighty angel, though fallen," and he most often disguises himself as a beautiful, dazzling "angel of light" to allure and deceive humanity (The Truth About Angels, "Angels at Christ's Baptism and in the Wilderness"; Testimonies for the Church, vol. 1, "Philosophy and Vain Deceit").

Since God created Lucifer, isn't He really responsible for sin? (af-248)God is not responsible for sin. He created Lucifer as a perfect, noble, and beautiful covering cherub (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 4, Comments on Ezekiel 28). However, God "takes no pleasure in a forced allegiance" and granted His creatures freedom of will. Lucifer willfully perverted this freedom, corrupting his own wisdom by indulging in pride and a desire for supremacy. The cross of Christ **"demonstrates to the whole universe that the course of sin which Lucifer had chosen was in no wise chargeable upon the government of God"** (Darkness Before Dawn, "Why Was Sin Permitted?").

Why does it seem like I'm being harassed by the devil after joining God's church? (af-250)This is a spiritual reality: **"Never is one received from the family of Satan into the family of God without exciting the determined resistance of the wicked one"** (Counsels for the Church, "Joshua and the Angel"). By seeking to advance God's truth, you draw the hatred of the powers of darkness. "The more

nearly the Christian imitates the divine Pattern, the more surely will he make himself a mark for the attacks of Satan" (From Here to Forever, "Satan and Man at War").

Why didn't God destroy the devil when he sinned and end the sin problem? (af-282) If God had instantly destroyed Satan, the unfallen angels and the rest of the universe **"would not have perceived the justice and love of God,"** and they **"would have served God from fear rather than from love"** (Christ's Object Lessons, "Tares"; From Here to Forever, "Why Was Sin Permitted?"). Satan was spared so he could fully develop his principles. This allows the entire universe to see the true, destructive nature of his rebellion, which will serve as a "perpetual safeguard to all holy intelligences" against sin for all eternity (From Here to Forever, "Why Was Sin Permitted?").

What does the Bible say about old wounds and bad experiences? (af-297) The sources warn heavily against dwelling on the dark side of your past or constantly talking about your trials and infirmities, as this makes you an "easy subject to Satan's devices" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 4, "A Divided Interest"). It is a mistake to keep the masterly working of the archdeceiver uppermost in the mind while losing sight of God's power. "We must talk of the mightiness of Christ" (Testimony Treasures, vol. 2, "The Sin Against the Holy Spirit"). Ultimately, God promises that in heaven, the painful trials and struggles of this life will be completely healed: **"The former shall not be remembered, nor come into mind"** (Selected Messages Book 3, "As We Near the End").

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here are the answers to your questions regarding the sanctuary, prophecy, and the investigative judgment. Please note that the provided texts do not explicitly explain **the specific meaning of the twelve stars on the woman's head in Revelation 12 (af-012)**, nor do they specifically address **whether it is safe to ask God for a sign to obey (af-241)**. You may want to independently verify those points in Scripture. Here is the comprehensive information on the other topics

covered in the texts:

What is the "abomination of desolation"? (af-007)As noted in our previous conversation, Jesus originally referred to the "abomination of desolation" in Matthew 24:15 as a sign for the early Christians to flee Judea before the destruction of Jerusalem by the Roman armies (From Here to Forever, "Forecast of the World's Destiny"). The sources draw a direct prophetic parallel between that ancient event and the modern Sunday Law, marking the time when the limit of God's forbearance is reached and the time of trouble is imminent (Testimony Treasures, vol. 2, "The Impending Conflict").

Who is the woman in Revelation 12:1? (af-012)In Bible prophecy, a woman is a symbol of a church. The pure woman of Revelation 12 represents God's true church, while the "remnant of her seed" represents the Christians of the last generation living just prior to the second advent who keep the commandments of God and have the testimony of Jesus Christ (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "The Church and World United").

Were there two sets of cherubim in the temple?

(af-067)Yes. In the temple built by Solomon, there were the original cherubim on the top of the ark (the mercy seat), and in addition to those, Solomon made two other angels of larger size that stood at each end of the ark (The Truth About Angels, "Angels From the Time of the Judges to the Early Kingdom"). These stately cherubim stood upon the floor with their wings stretched out, representing the heavenly angels always guarding the law of God.

Is it true that the little horn power in Daniel 8 was King Antiochus Epiphanes? (af-095)No. As established in our previous conversation, the claim that the little horn power and the 2300-day prophecy refer merely to Antiochus Epiphanes is a false theory historically used by critics to undermine the sanctuary truth. The biblical response maintains that Daniel 8 and 9 link the 2300 days to the 70 weeks, establishing an eschatological prophetic timeline reaching all the way to 1844, far beyond Antiochus (Sanctuary, 1844, and Investigative Judgment). In reality, the little horn power of Daniel 7 and 8 unquestionably points to the papacy, which thought to change times and laws (The

Great Controversy 1888, "God's Law Immutable").

Where is the Ark of the Covenant located today?

(af-156)The earthly Ark of the Covenant was secreted in a cave by righteous men just before the Babylonian captivity and the destruction of the temple, because of Israel's sins (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 4a, "The Ark of God"). It has never been disturbed since and remains hidden to this day. Meanwhile, the true, great original Ark of the Covenant is safely enshrined in the most holy place of the heavenly sanctuary, where it was seen by the apostle John in Revelation 11:19 (The Great Controversy, "God's Law Immutable").

Where are we in the timeline of the prophecies of

Revelation? (af-223)We are living in the "time of the end" and standing on the threshold of great and solemn events (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 9, "The Last Crisis"). The longest time prophecies—the 1260 days ending in 1798, and the 2300 days ending in 1844—have already been fulfilled. Since 1844, we have been in the antitypical Day of Atonement while the investigative judgment takes place in heaven. We are currently under the proclamation of the third angel's message. The very next major milestones to be fulfilled are the enforcement of the mark of the beast (the National Sunday Law), the close of human probation, and the outpouring of the seven last plagues (The Great Controversy, "The Impending Conflict").

In prophecy, does the symbol "beast" mean "beastly" characteristics? (af-226)The sources do not define the prophetic symbol of a "beast" as primarily meaning "beastly" characteristics. Rather, a beast in Bible prophecy represents a king, kingdom, or political and religious power (Sanctuary, 1844, and Investigative Judgment). For instance, the leopard-like beast of Revelation 13 represents the papacy, and the beast with lamb-like horns represents the United States (The Great Controversy 1888, "God's Law Immutable").

Is it possible to preach Jesus' end-time truth without including the three angels' messages? (af-227)No, it is not possible. The third angel's message, which embraces the first and second, is explicitly declared to be "the message for this time" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 8, "Our Message"). The sources emphasize that "the great center of

attraction, Jesus Christ, must not be left out of the third angel's message" (Selected Messages Book 1, "Christ the Center of the Message"). To preach Christ's end-time truth means heralding this threefold warning, as it is the testing truth designed by God to prepare a people to stand in the judgment (Testimonies to Ministers and Gospel Workers, "The Holy Scriptures").

Why did animals need to be sacrificed in the Old

Testament sanctuary services? (af-237) Animals needed to be sacrificed to impress upon humanity the sacred character of God's law, the guilt of sin, and its dire results (Christ in His Sanctuary, "Christ in the Sacrificial System"). The sacrificial offerings constituted a "perpetual reminder of the coming of a Saviour," teaching the people each day the great truths of Christ's substitutionary death and ministration (Prophets and Kings, "The Coming of a Deliverer"). The offering had to be "without blemish" because it served as a symbol of the perfect purity of the Son of God, who would offer Himself to atone for a rebellious race (From Eternity Past, "The Sanctuary: God's Dwelling Place in Israel").

Did Moses and Elijah actually appear with Jesus at the transfiguration, or was it only a vision? (af-242)

They actually appeared as literal, living beings. Moses died but was literally resurrected from the grave by Christ (Michael the Archangel) to be taken to heaven (The Truth About Angels, "Angels From Sinai to the Taking of Jericho"). Elijah, of course, was translated to heaven without ever seeing death. Thus, both Moses and Elijah were real, physical beings who came from heaven to talk with Jesus on the mount of transfiguration regarding the everlasting deliverance He was about to accomplish through the cross (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 4, Comments on Daniel 9:24).

Please note that the provided texts do not provide a mathematical or idiomatic explanation for how Jesus was in the tomb for **"three days and three nights" (af-019)**, nor do they provide a specific symbolic interpretation of the **Euphrates River drying up** to make way for the kings of the east in Revelation 16:12 (af-103). You may want to

independently verify those specific points.

Here is the comprehensive information from the sources regarding your other questions about final events and the end times:

Is the battle of Armageddon only a spiritual idea?

(af-006) It is not merely a spiritual idea; it is a literal and final battle, though rooted in a spiritual conflict. The texts declare that **"the battles waging between the two armies are as real as those fought by the armies of this world,"** and on the issue of this conflict, eternal destinies depend (Last Day Events, "The Seven Last Plagues and the Wicked"). The earth itself will be the literal battlefield where the final contest takes place and rebellion is forever suppressed (Last Day Events, "The Seven Last Plagues and the Wicked").

When the Bible says Babylon will never be rebuilt, is it just symbolic? / Did Satan's kingdom "Babylon"

originate at the tower of Babel? (af-016, af-251) The original, literal kingdom of Babylon did originate at the Tower of Babel. The term "Babylon" is derived from "Babel," and signifies confusion (The Great Controversy, "Warning Rejected"). The builders at Babel established their kingdom for self-exaltation, introducing a mixture of religious ideas with erroneous theories (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 1, Chapter 11). While ancient Babylon literally fell and passed away completely as a political empire never to be rebuilt (Prophets and Kings, "The Unseen Watcher"), in the book of Revelation, **Babylon is used "spiritually" or symbolically as a woman representing the various forms of false or apostate churches in the last days** (The Great Controversy, "Warning Rejected").

Doesn't the Bible teach in Luke 17 that there will be a rapture? / Is there a danger Christians will be caught off guard? / If Jesus is coming "as a thief in the night,"

how can anyone know? (af-018, af-118, af-253) The sources do not support the modern doctrine of a secret rapture. The Second Coming will be universally known, visible, and glorious: **"This coming, there is no possibility of counterfeiting. It will be universally known—witnessed by the whole world"** (The Great Controversy, "The Time of Trouble").

However, many Christians will indeed be caught off guard. Jesus comes "as a thief" only to those who are unwatchful and asleep in carnal security, saying "Peace and safety" (The Great Controversy, "A Great Religious Awakening"). To the faithful who heed the signs, Paul writes: **"Ye, brethren, are not in darkness, that that day should overtake you as a thief"** (The Great Controversy, "A Great Religious Awakening"). The parable of the ten virgins demonstrates that even among those claiming to wait for Christ, half will be found "surprised, dismayed, outside the banquet hall" (Christ's Object Lessons, "To Meet the Bridegroom").

Is the mark of the beast a tattoo? / What are the two horns of Revelation 13:11? (af-039, af-081) The mark of the beast is **not a literal tattoo or visible physical mark** (Last Day Events, "The Seal of God and the Mark of the Beast"). It is a spiritual mark of allegiance—specifically, the observance of Sunday (the papal sabbath) enforced by the state in direct opposition to God's seventh-day Sabbath (The Great Controversy, "God's Law Immutable"). The power that enforces this mark is the beast with two lamb-like horns (Revelation 13:11), which represents the United States of America. Its lamb-like horns symbolize the nation's foundational principles of civil and religious liberty—**Republicanism and Protestantism** (The Great Controversy, "God's Law Immutable").

What is the Christian's responsibility to the state? / Doesn't it make good sense for governments to pass laws enforcing Christianity? (af-055, af-244) It does not make good sense for governments to pass laws enforcing Christianity. Compulsory worship is not acceptable to God and is the hallmark of the papacy (The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 4, "Appendix"). When the state is used to enforce religious decrees, it destroys liberty of conscience and forms an "image to the beast," leading directly to persecution (The Great Controversy, "The Impending Conflict"). The Christian's responsibility to the state is generally obedience, as God restrains rulers and uses civil laws to maintain order in an awful world (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 1, "Oath Taking"). However, **when human laws conflict with God's law, believers must obey God rather than men** (The Great Controversy, "The Scriptures a Safeguard"). Even

then, believers are advised not to needlessly provoke the state; to avoid defying Sunday laws aggressively, they should refrain from ordinary work and devote Sunday to missionary effort, while continuing to keep the seventh-day Sabbath holy (Last Day Events, "Sunday Laws").

What are the “wars and rumors of wars” spoken of by Christ? / Isn’t the great tribulation yet to come?

(af-088, af-113)When Christ spoke of "wars and rumors of wars" and "great tribulation," His prophecy was twofold. It first pointed to the impending destruction of Jerusalem and the subsequent 1260 years of terrible papal persecution against the church during the Dark Ages, a tribulation that was "shortened" for the elect's sake (The Desire of Ages, "On the Mount of Olives"). However, it also has a more direct application to the final days, pointing to the future "time of Jacob's trouble"—**a time of unparalleled global distress, war, and persecution just before the final deliverance of God's people** (The Great Controversy, "The Destruction of Jerusalem"; The Great Controversy, "The Time of Trouble").

Does the Bible teach there is more than one antichrist? / Is the antichrist a person or something else?

(af-096, af-224)The Bible teaches that there are "many antichrists" who deceive the world, applying the term to **"all who exalt themselves against the will and work of God"** (The Youth's Instructor, "Continue in the Son and in the Father"; Testimonies to Ministers and Gospel Workers, "A False Message"). However, prophecy identifies a primary, systemic Antichrist—the "man of sin" or the papacy, a religious-political system that claims the right to change God's law (The Great Controversy, "God's Law Immutable"). Additionally, at the very end of time, Satan himself will personally act as the ultimate Antichrist by assuming a human form to personate Jesus Christ (The Great Controversy, "The Time of Trouble").

Will every person on Earth actually be reached with the gospel before Jesus returns? / Will the temple be rebuilt in Jerusalem before Jesus returns?

(af-100, af-183)The everlasting gospel is to be preached "to every nation, and kindred, and tongue, and people" as a witness before the end comes (Christ's Object Lessons, "Go into the

Highways and Hedges"). However, Christ does not say that every person will be *converted*, but rather that **all will be reached with the warning** (The Desire of Ages, "On the Mount of Olives"). Regarding the temple, "Old Jerusalem never would be built up." Looking for a rebuilt temple in the Middle East is a deception designed by Satan to distract minds from the present work of Christ in the heavenly sanctuary (Early Writings, "The Gathering Time").

What does the Bible mean when it says there will come a time when people who kill Christians think they are helping God? (af-102) In the final crisis, Satan will persuade the masses that those who keep the seventh-day Sabbath are offending God and are the direct cause of global calamities, disasters, and plagues (The Great Controversy, "The Impending Conflict"). Religious and secular authorities will conclude that these few dissidents are preventing the restoration of divine favor to the earth. **Therefore, those who seek to destroy the faithful will actually "think that he is doing God service" because they believe executing them will appease God's wrath** (Sketches from the Life of Paul, "Chapter XXX"; The Great Controversy, "The Impending Conflict").

What are the false teachings in the "wine" of Babylon? / Will the New Age movement play a role in the endtime conflict? (af-249, af-252) The "wine" of Babylon represents the false doctrines that apostate churches have accepted from Rome and forced upon the world. These include **the exaltation of the false sabbath (Sunday), the natural immortality of the soul, and the eternal torment of the wicked** (Testimonies to Ministers and Gospel Workers, "A False Message"; The Great Controversy, "Warning Rejected"). While the modern term "New Age" is not used, its underlying philosophies play a major role. Through **"higher criticism, evolution, spiritualism, theosophy, and pantheism,"** Satan seeks to lead souls into forbidden paths (From Trials to Triumph, "Letters Paul Wrote From Rome"). The teachings of spiritualism remove moral restraints, open the door to "doctrines of devils," and represent the masterpiece of Satan's deception for the last days (The Great Controversy, "Can Our Dead Speak to Us?").

When will Christ set up His kingdom upon the earth? / Should we hear more teaching today about Christ's second coming? (af-283, af-284) Christ's eternal kingdom will not be established on the earth until *after* the millennium. Following the thousand years, the New Jerusalem will descend, the fires of the last day will purify the earth, and "**when all who oppose the sovereignty of Christ have been destroyed, the kingdoms of this world become the kingdoms of our Lord**" (Patriarchs and Prophets, "Appendix Note 8"). Because this event is the culmination of all history, the blessed hope of the second appearing of Christ needs to be often presented to the people today. "**The return of Christ to our world will not be long delayed. Let this be the keynote of every message,**" as it leads believers to regard earthly things as emptiness and prepares them for the solemn realities ahead (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Preparation for the Final Crisis").

Please note that the provided sources do not contain information explaining **why God sought to kill Moses (af-119), whether the Gospels differ on the events of the resurrection (af-164), specific Bible verses proving Joseph was previously married (af-204), or the difference between accepting Jesus as your Saviour versus Lord (the prompt cut off at "my?") (af-247)**. You may want to independently verify those specific points. Here are the answers to your other questions regarding the nature and work of Christ:

Isn't it a contradiction that God spoke to Moses "face to face," yet no man can see His face and live? (af-017) It is not a contradiction, because Christ mercifully veiled His unapproachable glory so Moses would not be destroyed. The sources explain that the "all-merciful God shrouded His glory in a most humble type, that Moses could look upon it and live" (The Desire of Ages, "God With Us"). Even when Moses was placed in the cleft of the rock to view God, the Lord covered him with His hand and only allowed His "goodness" to pass before him, shielding Moses from the consuming brightness of full divine glory (Help in Daily

Living, "Pressing Toward the Mark").

Did Jesus say that Peter was the foundation of the church? (af-042)No. When Jesus said "upon this rock I will build my church," He was referring to Himself. The texts state: **"The word 'Peter' signifies a loose stone. Christ did not refer to Peter as being the rock upon which He would found His church. His expression 'this rock,' applied to Himself as the foundation of the Christian church"** (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, Chapter 16).

Who is the woman's seed bruising the serpent's head? (af-043)The "seed of the woman" is Jesus Christ. He is the Promised One who was prophesied in Eden to crush the power of Satan (From Heaven With Love, "Jesus Acclaimed as Israel's King"; The Great Hope, "Hope for Triumph Over Evil").

How could Jesus say some would not taste death until they see Him coming in His kingdom? (af-044)This promise was literally fulfilled just days later on the Mount of Transfiguration. The sources explain: **"Upon the mount the future kingdom of glory was represented in miniature—Christ the King, Moses a representative of the risen saints, and Elijah of the translated ones"** (Heaven, "Face-to-Face at Last"). Peter, James, and John were thus permitted to see Christ in His kingdom glory before they died.

How can Jesus bring peace, but the Bible also says He came to bring a sword? (af-074)The gospel is inherently a message of peace that would unite all humanity in brotherhood if universally accepted. However, because the world is controlled by Satan, the pure principles of Christ are "wholly at variance with their habits and desires" (From Here to Forever, "First Christians—Loyal and True"). The wicked hate the purity that condemns their sins, leading them to persecute the righteous. **It is in this sense—because the exalted truths of the gospel occasion hatred, strife, and persecution from the wicked—that Christ's message acts as a sword** (From Here to Forever, "First Christians—Loyal and True").

How can the Lord say, "I never knew you" when He knows everybody? (af-106)God knows everyone's actions, but the phrase "I never knew you" means He never knew

them in a *saving, experimental relationship*. People may profess His name and even point to wonderful miracles done, but if they continue to transgress the law of God, their works are "done under the supervision of the enemy of righteousness" to deceive souls (True Revival, "Beware the Counterfeits"). Because they never exercised genuine repentance or surrendered their hearts, Christ cannot acknowledge them as His true followers (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, Chapter 3).

Doesn't Revelation 3:14 teach that Jesus was created?

(af-146)The sources strongly deny the theory that Christ was created. Jesus possessed "**life, original, unborrowed, underived**" and existed "from all eternity" (The Desire of Ages, "The Light of Life"; Selected Messages Book 1, "The Word Made Flesh"). The text asserts, "If Christ made all things, He existed before all things... Christ was God essentially, and in the highest sense" (Selected Messages Book 1, "The Word Made Flesh").

What did Jesus do before His ministry began?

(af-163)Jesus lived an obscure life in the town of Nazareth, working manually. "**He was a carpenter, working for wages, a servant to those for whom He labored**" (Evangelism, "Misrepresentations of the Godhead"). His fellow townsmen knew Him as the carpenter's son because they had seen Him "toiling up and down the hills" for nearly thirty years (The Desire of Ages, "Is Not This the Carpenter's Son?").

Did Jesus use His divine power to only do good things for others? (af-167)Yes. "**Christ worked no miracles in His own behalf**" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, Chapter 22). When Satan tempted Him to turn stones into bread, Christ refused, because "He was not to exercise divine power for His own benefit. He had come to bear trial as we must, leaving us an example. His wonderful works were all for the good of others" (From Heaven With Love, "The Wilderness Temptation").

Who is the "I AM" spoken of in the Bible? (af-176)Jesus Christ is the "I AM." It was Christ who spoke from the burning bush to Moses, saying "I AM THAT I AM." When He came to earth in human likeness, He announced Himself to the Jews as the self-existent One, declaring, "Before

Abraham was, I AM" (The Desire of Ages, "God With Us"; The Desire of Ages, "The Light of Life").

Was Jesus human or divine when He was on this earth?

(af-181)He was completely both. **"The two natures were mysteriously blended in one person—the man Christ Jesus. In Him dwelt all the fullness of the Godhead bodily"** (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7A, "The Mystery of the Incarnation"). Divinity was clothed with humanity, but "He did not cease to be God when He became man... Though Christ humbled Himself to become man, the Godhead was still His own" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, Chapter 1).

What kind of body does Jesus have right now—

physical or spirit? (af-234)Jesus currently has a literal, glorified human body. When He ascended, **"Christ took with Him to the heavenly courts His glorified humanity"** (The Ministry of Healing, "True Knowledge of God"). He "stands before God as the representative of our race" and "has carried His humanity into eternity," forever retaining His human nature as a pledge of God's love for humanity (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7, Chapter 2; SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7A, "Atoning Sacrifice").

Must you be baptized to be saved? What about the

thief on the cross? (af-027)Baptism is "the sign of entrance to His spiritual kingdom" and is a "positive condition with which all must comply who wish to be acknowledged as under the authority of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Baptism"). The requisite steps in conversion are clearly defined as "repentance, faith, and baptism" (Evangelism, "Baptism and Church Membership"; The Story of Redemption, "The Gentiles Receive the Holy Spirit"). However, the act alone holds no saving merit; "apart from Christ, baptism, like any other service, is a worthless form" (The Desire of Ages, "He Must Increase"). *The provided sources do not specifically address the thief on the cross regarding the requirements of baptism.*

When do you receive the Holy Spirit—before, during, or after baptism? (af-029)The Holy Spirit is active in all phases of the believer's experience. The Spirit draws the

sinner and brings about the "change of heart, of thoughts and purposes" that prepares a candidate for baptism (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Baptism"). When a believer is baptized in the threefold name of the Godhead, these three great powers (including the Holy Spirit) are present and "pledge themselves that every facility shall be given to us if we carry out our baptismal vows" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, "Chapter 6"). Additionally, the Scriptures record instances where a special outpouring or baptism of the Holy Spirit was given through the laying on of hands *after* water baptism, enabling believers for special missionary service (The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 3, "Apollos at Corinth").

Does John 9:31 teach that God doesn't hear sinners?

(af-063) God absolutely hears the prayers of sinners who come to Him in sincere repentance. "The prayer of the penitent, contrite soul is always accepted," and the very fact that you "feel and know that you are a sinner is sufficient argument in asking for His mercy and compassion" (Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer"; Selected Messages Book 1, "Come and Seek and Find"). However, if a sinner refuses to repent and clings to their sins, their prayers will not be answered. "If we regard iniquity in our hearts, if we cling to any known sin, the Lord will not hear us" (Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer").

Does Ezekiel teach that we should baptize by sprinkling? / Does the Bible teach that we should be baptized on behalf of our dead relatives? / Is having a private baptism without a pastor present biblically valid? (af-073, af-087, af-209) *The provided sources do not discuss Ezekiel in relation to the mode of baptism, the practice of baptizing for dead relatives, or whether a private baptism without an ordained pastor is biblically valid.*

However, the sources describe biblical baptism as a burial, noting that candidates are "buried beneath the water" and go down into a "watery grave," which indicates full immersion (The Desire of Ages, "The Baptism"; Pastoral Ministry, "Baptism").

Shouldn't we be baptized in Jesus' name only?

(af-116) No, believers are to be baptized in the name of the Trinity. Christ commanded His disciples to baptize "in the

name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost" (The Acts of the Apostles, "The Great Commission"). At the entrance of the Christian life, believers are "baptized in the threefold name," acknowledging the authority of all three persons of the Godhead (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Baptism").

Should infants be baptized? / How old should one be to qualify for baptism? (af-123, af-275) While the sources do not specify a numerical age, they indicate that infants are not to be baptized because baptism requires instruction, understanding, and personal repentance. "Candidates who have grown to manhood and womanhood should understand their duty better than do the younger ones," and there should be a "thorough understanding as to its meaning" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Baptism"). Parents are instructed that there should be "no undue haste to receive the ordinance" and they must ensure their children understand it means "repentance for sin, and the entrance upon a new life" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Baptism").

Does the Bible teach men can forgive sins? (af-131) No. "To no man, to no body of men, is given power to free the soul from guilt" (The Desire of Ages, "Peace Be Unto You"). Christ gave no ecclesiastical right or liberty for men to forgive sin or to sell indulgences (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, "Chapter 20"). The church has the power to absolve sins only in the sense of "assuring the repenting sinner of the forgiving mercy of the Saviour" and leading them to the light of faith (The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 3, "The Ascension of Christ").

What does Jesus mean when He says believers will speak with new tongues? (af-136) This promise was gloriously fulfilled at Pentecost, when the disciples received the baptism of the Holy Spirit, "by which they were enabled to speak the languages of other nations and to prophesy" to spread the gospel globally (The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 3, "Apollos at Corinth"). The sources strongly warn against modern counterfeits where people use an "unmeaning gibberish which they call the unknown tongue, which is unknown not only by man but by the Lord and all heaven," calling it a fanaticism manufactured by Satan (Testimony

Treasures, vol. 1, "Counterfeit Gifts of the Spirit").

What are the “keys of the kingdom”? (af-144)“The keys of the kingdom of heaven' are the words of Christ. All the words of Holy Scripture are His. These words have power to open and to shut heaven" (From Heaven With Love, "Who Is the Greatest?").

What is the meaning of baptism? (af-160)Baptism is "a most solemn renunciation of the world" wherein the believer publicly declares that they have forsaken the service of Satan and have become a child of the heavenly King (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Baptism"). It commemorates Christ's resurrection; the believer goes down into the "watery grave in likeness of His resurrection, to live in newness of life" (Pastoral Ministry, "Baptism"; SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, "Chapter 16").

What is the proper posture for prayer? Is it always necessary to kneel? (af-182)It is our privilege and duty to "bow on our knees before the Lord when we offer our petitions to Him" in both public and private worship, demonstrating our reverence and dependence upon God (Gospel Workers, "Public Prayer"; Selected Messages Book 2, "Proper Attitude in Prayer"). However, it is not *always* necessary to kneel. The sources clarify: "We cannot always be on our knees in prayer, but the way to the mercy seat is always open." Believers should cultivate the habit of talking with the Saviour while walking, in crowds, or when busy with daily labor (Prayer, "Attitudes in Prayer"; The Ministry of Healing, "Help for the Unemployed and the Homeless").

Is it necessary to pray “In Jesus’ name” at the end of every prayer? (af-184)To pray in Christ's name is not a magic formula. "To pray in the name of Jesus is something more than a mere mention of that name at the beginning and the ending of a prayer. It is to pray in the mind and spirit of Jesus, while we believe His promises, rely upon His grace, and work His works" (Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer").

Where is the line between persisting in prayer and vain repetition? (af-212)Vain repetition is characterized by "set, customary phrases, when the heart feels no need of God," representing a pagan idea that prayers have intrinsic merit based on their length (Prayer, "Counterfeit Prayers").

Persisting in prayer, by contrast, is driven by deep soul-hunger. God commands believers to "unwearyingly persist in prayer" because the persistent asking brings the petitioner into a more earnest attitude and increases their desire to receive the blessing (Prayer, "Prevailing Prayer"; Prayer, "Answered Prayer").

Must a person first overcome every bad habit before being baptized? (af-219)Yes, known sins must be abandoned before taking this solemn vow. Pastors are instructed to have special meetings with candidates to ensure they understand their duty: "Evil habits are to be given up. The sins of evilspeaking, of jealousy, of disobedience, are to be put away. A warfare must be waged against every evil trait of character" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Baptism"). However, this overcoming is not done in one's own strength, but through total reliance on the Holy Spirit and Christ's grace.

Did people have the Holy Spirit before the day of Pentecost? (af-285)Yes. The Holy Spirit was active before Pentecost; for example, John the Baptist was "filled with the Holy Ghost" to prepare the way for Christ (The Truth About Angels, "Angels From the Captivity to John the Baptist"). However, at Pentecost, the Spirit descended upon the disciples in "rich currents" and "without measure" as Heaven's communication that the Redeemer's inauguration in the heavenly sanctuary was accomplished (The Acts of the Apostles, "The Gift of the Spirit"; The Truth About Angels, "Angels in the Great Hereafter").

What can I do or say so that my prayers are actually answered? (af-288)The sources outline specific conditions for answered prayer:

1. **Recognize your need:** You must hunger and thirst after righteousness (Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer").
2. **Forsake known sin:** "If we regard iniquity in our hearts, if we cling to any known sin, the Lord will not hear us" (Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer").
3. **Exercise faith:** You must believe that God rewards those who diligently seek Him, and you must trust

His promises rather than your changeable feelings
(Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer"; Selected
Messages Book 1, "Come and Seek and Find").

4. **Forgive others:** You must have a spirit of love and forgiveness toward others if you expect God to forgive your trespasses (Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer").
5. **Persevere:** You must be "instant in prayer" and not give up when answers are delayed (Steps to Christ, "The Privilege of Prayer").
6. **Obey:** You must live in harmony with your petitions. "They are of no avail if we walk contrary to them" (Child Guidance, "Sabbath-The Day of Delight").

Does it really make a difference to pray on behalf of other people? (af-296) It makes an immense difference. "In rescuing souls from his devices, far more will be accomplished by Christlike, humble prayer than by many words without prayer" (Colporteur Ministry, "The Canvasser a Gospel Worker"). Furthermore, intercessory prayer blesses the one praying: "The Lord turned the captivity of Job when he prayed, not only for himself, but for those who were opposing him... No one prays aright who seeks a blessing for himself alone" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 3, "Chapter 42"; Prayer, "Intercessory Prayer").

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here are the answers to your questions regarding God's nature, character, and the problem of evil.

Please note that the provided texts do not address several of your specific questions. They do not explain **why God allowed David to keep Bathsheba (af-008), the issue of blood transfusions (af-034), any statute regarding slavery or a curse against a certain race (af-036), who Cain was specifically worried would kill him (af-065), how Jesus is the "firstborn from the dead" when others were raised before Him (af-071), or the exact geographical location of the Garden of Eden (af-161).** You will need to consult outside biblical resources for those specific answers.

Here is the comprehensive information on the other topics covered in the sources:

How could David be called a man after God's own heart when he committed adultery? (af-008) David was not called a man after God's own heart while he was sinning. The sources clarify: **"It was when David was pure, and walking in the counsel of God, that God called him a man after his own heart"** (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 4a, "Samuel and Saul"). When he departed from God and stained his character with crimes, that title ceased to be true of him until he returned to the Lord through deep, remorseful repentance. God did not justify his sins in the least degree, but sent the prophet Nathan with dreadful denunciations, and David reaped a baleful harvest of judgments from his own house (Patriarchs and Prophets, "David's Sin and Repentance").

Are the days in Genesis 1 and 2 literal or symbolic of long periods of time? (af-011) The days of creation were **literal, 24-hour days**. The Bible states that each day consisted of an evening and a morning, "like every other day since that time" (Education, "Science and the Bible"). The weekly cycle of six days for labor and the seventh for rest originated from these first seven literal days. The sources warn that claiming these days represent "vast, indefinite periods" is a dangerous disguise for infidelity, designed by Satan to strike directly at the foundation of the fourth commandment (the Sabbath) and to impeach the wisdom of God (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "Disguised Infidelity").

Does the Bible support having multiple wives? (af-013) No, **the Bible does not support polygamy**. In the beginning, God gave Adam one wife, establishing His divine order, and "He never designed that man should have a plurality of wives" (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "Tower of Babel"). Lamech was the first to depart from this arrangement, which created discord and misery. The texts state explicitly: **"God has not sanctioned polygamy in a single instance. It was contrary to his will. He knew that the happiness of man would be destroyed by it"** (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "Abraham").

Why does the Bible say the Lord is a "jealous God" when jealousy is wrong? (af-015) In the context of the Ten

Commandments, the close relationship between God and His people is represented under the figure of marriage. Because God requires supreme allegiance, **"Idolatry being spiritual adultery, the displeasure of God against it is fitly called jealousy"** (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Law Given to Israel").

Wasn't it too harsh to stone someone for breaking the Sabbath? (af-053) The man who was stoned for gathering sticks on the Sabbath committed a "willful and deliberate violation of the fourth commandment—a sin of presumption" (From Eternity Past, "The Grace of Christ and the New Covenant"). In the theocracy of ancient Israel, **willful Sabbathbreaking and blasphemy received the same severe punishment because both were equally an expression of open contempt for the authority of the great Lawgiver** (From Eternity Past, "The Grace of Christ and the New Covenant"; SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 4, Comments on Jeremiah 20:12, 13). Justice demanded strict punishment to preserve the nation from utter depravity and rebellion.

Why didn't Adam and Eve die the very day they sinned? (af-101) The warning "in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die" did not imply that Adam and Eve would instantly drop dead upon tasting the fruit. Rather, it meant that **"on that day the irrevocable sentence would be pronounced"** (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Temptation and Fall"). By transgressing, they forfeited their right to eternal life and were doomed to eventually die.

Furthermore, the full execution of the death sentence was temporarily withheld because "a ransom was found"—the Son of God stepped in and volunteered to take the sin of man upon Himself, providing a period of probation (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 1, Comments on Genesis 2:17).

Why did God create our world if He knew we would fall into sin? (af-162) God did not ordain sin, but He foresaw the terrible emergency it would create and made provision to meet it (The Truth About Angels, "Angels in Heaven, Before the Rebellion"). **God desires the voluntary service of love from His creatures, which inherently requires the freedom to choose** (The Great Controversy, "The Origin of Evil"). He created humanity for His own glory,

purposing that after a period of test and trial, the faithful members of the human family would "become one with the heavenly family" and fill the vacancies left in heaven by the fall of Satan and his angels (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 1, Comments on Genesis 1:26; The Truth About Angels, "The Rebellious Angels Are Cast Out, and Adam and Eve Fall").

Why does the Bible share repugnant and graphic

descriptions of sin? (af-240)The Holy Spirit did not

conceal the frailties and faults of Bible characters because

"The principles of justice required a faithful narration of facts for the benefit of all who should ever read the Sacred Record" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 4, "Bible Biographies").

These graphic records are essential for two reasons: First, to serve as a warning that "the wages of sin is death" and that God's retributive justice never fails.

Second, to provide hope—by showing where great leaders struggled, fell, and conquered again through God's grace, teaching us that God pities and forgives the repenting sinner (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 4, "Bible Biographies").

Does God cause natural disasters? (af-290)No. **Satan is the destroyer who causes these calamities.**

Satan has studied the secrets of nature and uses his power to control the elements as far as God allows. As the world increasingly rejects God's law, God removes His protecting care. Then, "While appearing as a great physician who can heal all their maladies, Satan will bring disease and disaster until populous cities are reduced to ruin." He is the one exercising his power in earthquakes, tempests, tornadoes, floods, and tidal waves (The Great Hope, "Real Hope"; The Great Controversy, "The Impending Conflict").

Does God heal people today as He did in Bible times?

(af-301)Yes. The sources affirm that the healing power of the Creator is still active. **"The words spoken to Israel are true today of those who recover health of body or health of soul. 'I am the Lord that healeth thee.'"** (The Ministry of Healing, "Co-Working of the Divine and the Human").

Please note that the provided sources do not explicitly explain the historical process of how the books of the Bible were originally chosen for the canon (af-158), whether the Shroud of Turin is a real biblical artifact (af-206), when the Bible was first published (af-221), or the dangers of specific new Bible versions or modern translations (af-222). You may want to independently verify those historical and archaeological points.

Here is the comprehensive information from the sources regarding your other questions:

Is all of the Bible inspired or only parts of it?

(af-231) All of the Bible is inspired, and the sources strongly warn against the practice of dissecting the Scriptures to judge what is inspired and what is not. The author declares, "I take the Bible just as it is, as the Inspired Word. I believe its utterances in an entire Bible" (Selected Messages Book 1, "The Inspiration of the Prophetic Writers"). No finite human is qualified to pronounce judgment on God's Word by selecting some things as inspired and discrediting others as uninspired (Selected Messages Book 1, "The Inspiration of the Prophetic Writers").

How can anyone believe the Bible is inspired when it's

full of errors? (af-233) The Bible points to God as its author, yet it was written by human hands and expressed in the imperfect language of men (The Great Controversy, "Introduction"). Because several writers present subjects under varied aspects and from different perspectives, "there may appear, to the superficial, careless, or prejudiced reader, to be discrepancy or contradiction, where the thoughtful, reverent student, with clearer insight, discerns the underlying harmony" (Selected Messages Book 1, "Ellen G. White and Her Writings"). The difficulties in the Bible do not reflect upon the wisdom of God, but are due to man's perversion of it or the narrowness of the human mind, which cannot fully grasp the infinite (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 5, "The Mysteries of the Bible a Proof of its Inspiration").

If the Bible is truly God's book, shouldn't everyone be able to understand it? (af-232) The great truths necessary for salvation are "made clear as the noonday," and the Bible was designed for the common people so that no one need

lose their way (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 5, "The Mysteries of the Bible a Proof of its Inspiration"). However, God has not removed all mysteries. The finite mind cannot fully comprehend the Infinite One. When the Bible is opened without reverence or prayer, or by those who love sin and approach it with pride, their minds are clouded with doubt, and they find it obscure (Steps to Christ, "What to Do with Doubt"). If men would simply take the Bible as it reads with a humble, teachable spirit, the Holy Spirit would guide them into all truth (The Great Controversy, "The Scriptures a Safeguard").

How do you know if a prophet is true or false?

(af-189)As established in our previous conversation, the Bible gives four specific tests to judge a prophet:

1. Their teachings must harmonize with the law and the testimony (Isaiah 8:20).
2. They must bear good fruit in their life and teachings (Matthew 7:15-20).
3. Their predictions must accurately come to pass (Deuteronomy 18:21, 22).
4. They must confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh, exalting the Son of God rather than themselves (1 John 4:1-3) (Christian Experience and Teachings of Ellen G. White, "Tested by the Word"; Counsels for the Church, "The Testimonies and the Reader").

Should we expect modern prophets to originate new doctrines? (af-255)No. Modern prophets are not given to originate new doctrines or a new rule of faith. God gives visions in the last days "not for a new rule of faith, but for the comfort of His people, and to correct those who err from Bible truth" (A Sketch of the Christian Experience and Views of Ellen G. White, "The Last Plagues and the Judgment"). The Spirit of Prophecy is a "lesser light to lead men and women to the greater light," bringing minds back to the Word of God that they have neglected (Selected Messages Book 3, "The Primacy of the Word").

If the Bible is the sole source of truth, shouldn't we reject all modern-day prophets? (af-256)To reject true

modern prophets is to reject the teachings of the Bible itself. The Bible explicitly states that the gifts of the Spirit—including prophecy—were "set" in the church to bring the saints to unity and perfection, and there is no scriptural proof that God ever abolished them (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 1, "Introduction"). The Spirit was not given to supersede the Bible, but the Bible commands believers to "Despise not prophesyings. Prove all things; hold fast that which is good" (Counsels for the Church, "The Testimonies and the Reader").

Do you think more true prophets will appear between now and Jesus' second coming? (af-257) Yes, the Scriptures clearly promise this. Joel 2:28-32 prophesies that in the "last days" God will pour out His Spirit upon all flesh, causing sons and daughters to prophesy and see visions (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 1, "Introduction"; Christian Experience and Teachings of Ellen G. White, "The Prophetic Gift"). Furthermore, Revelation 12:17 indicates that the remnant church just prior to Christ's coming will be distinguished by keeping the commandments of God and having the "testimony of Jesus Christ," which Revelation 19:10 defines as the Spirit of Prophecy (Christian Experience and Teachings of Ellen G. White, "The Prophetic Gift"). Because the final conflict is approaching, the manifestation of this gift is necessary to guide the church through the raging tempests of the last days (The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 1, "The Spirit of Prophecy").

Please note that the provided texts do not explicitly explain a specific Bible verse that simply says "**don't bring**" (af-124), nor do they discuss the modern legal procedure of **filing for bankruptcy (af-180)**. You may want to independently verify the biblical and legal contexts for those specific questions. However, the sources do address bringing vain oblations to God and the biblical principles regarding debt.

Here is the comprehensive information on the topics covered in your query:

Do Christians need to tithe? (af-020) Yes, tithing is a strict requirement for Christians. The system of tithes and

offerings did not originate with Moses, but reaches back to the days of Adam, and **"the New Testament does not re-enact the law of the tithe, as it does not that of the Sabbath; for the validity of both is assumed"** (Last Day Events, "The Seven Last Plagues and the Righteous"). Christ Himself recognized the payment of tithes as a duty, and the expansion of the gospel to the entire world in the Christian age actually made the law of tithes and offerings of *more* urgent necessity than it was under the Hebrew economy (The Desire of Ages, "Woe Unto You, Pharisees!"; Patriarchs and Prophets, "Tithes and Offerings").

Is it okay to refuse to pay tithe if I don't agree with what the church is doing with it? (af-246) No, it is never acceptable to withhold your tithe because of a disagreement with church management. The texts are very clear:

"Unworthy ministers may receive some of the means thus raised, but dare any one, because of this, withhold from the treasury, and brave the curse of God? I dare not" (Pastoral Ministry, "Finance"). If you believe the management is wrong, you should make your complaints plainly and openly to the proper authorities to correct the evil, but you must not commit sin yourself by robbing God of His property. The tithe is sacred, and those who meddle with it or withhold it will be punished with the loss of their heavenly treasure (Gospel Workers, "The Use of the Tithe"; Pastoral Ministry, "Finance").

What all is involved with proper Christian stewardship? (af-258) Proper Christian stewardship is founded on the recognition of God's absolute ownership of all things. **"We are stewards, supplied from God with talents and facilities, and placed in the world to do a work appointed by Him"** (Education, "Business Principles and Methods"). It involves:

- Returning a faithful tenth of all increase to God, along with freewill and gratitude offerings (Counsels for the Church, "Counsels on Stewardship").
- Caring for the poor, the widow, the orphan, and the sick (The Ministry of Healing, "The Helpless Poor").

- Practicing strict economy and denying self-indulgence, extravagance, and pride so that more means can flow into the work of saving souls (The Adventist Home, "Stewards of God").
- Using all of our time, health, mental faculties, and influence to advance the kingdom of Christ and represent His character to the world (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 6, "Giving to God His Own").

Is it proper to leave an inheritance to unconverted children who might squander it? (af-200)No. The sources state that parents commit a terrible mistake and a sin against the Master when they place God's means in the hands of unbelieving children merely because they are their children. **"If they have unbelieving children who have abundance of this world, and who are serving the world, they commit a sin against the Master... by placing means in their hands"** (Counsels for the Church, "Counsels on Stewardship"). Leaving property to heirs who do not love God simply places that money into Satan's ranks. Furthermore, inherited wealth nine times out of ten proves to be a curse, a snare, and a root of bitterness that ruins the children for both this life and eternity (The Retirement Years, "Stewardship While Living").

If we believe Jesus is coming soon, is it a lack of faith for us to prepare for retirement or emergencies? (af-216)No, saving for emergencies or times of inability to work is not a lack of faith; it is wise management. The sources rebuke individuals who spend all they earn and fail to plan for the future. **"Every week a portion of your wages should be reserved and in no case touched unless suffering actual want... Your family should have something to rely upon if you should be brought into straitened places"** (The Adventist Home, "Provision for the Future"). Young men are specifically counseled to be diligent and save so they will have a "competency untouched should you become sick, that the charities of others would not be your dependence" (Selected Messages Book 2, "Providing for the Day of Need"). While hoarding wealth is a sin, saving a practical margin is highly encouraged.

Should a Christian ever file bankruptcy? (af-180)While

the legal process of bankruptcy is not specifically detailed, the financial habits that lead to it are strongly condemned, and Christians are commanded to pay their debts. **"Many poor families are poor because they spend their money as soon as they receive it,"** and many men become bankrupt because they seek to gratify the extravagant tastes of their families (The Adventist Home, "Economy to be Practiced"). Believers are instructed to shun debt like the smallpox. The counsel is: **"Make a solemn covenant with God that by His blessing you will pay your debts and then owe no man anything if you live on porridge and bread... Deny your taste, deny the indulgence of appetite, save your pence, and pay your debts"** (The Adventist Home, "Business Integrity").

Are preachers today paid too much money according to godly stewardship? (af-260) The sources present a balanced view on this. On one hand, **it is not God's will for ministers to seek to be rich**, and those who demand "large wages" are sapping the Lord's treasury, binding up God's money in private interests, and revealing a lack of self-sacrifice (Selected Messages Book 2, "General Principles Governing Worker Remuneration"). On the other hand, the church is sternly rebuked for defrauding ministers of their just dues. **Ministers should receive wages sufficient to support themselves and their families comfortably.** It is a "terrible injustice" and a "criminal" act in the sight of God for auditing committees to force laborers to accept small remuneration simply because the treasury is depleted (Pastoral Ministry, "Salary"; The Acts of the Apostles, "A Liberal Church"). A true estimate must be placed upon talent, and faithful workers are absolutely "worthy of their hire."

Does the Bible say it is wrong to gamble? (af-265) Yes, gambling is condemned as a destructive evil. The sources warn that acquiring money without labor is deeply intoxicating and demoralizing, especially to the youth. The texts specifically denounce **"church fairs, charitable raffles, concert lotteries for charitable and other purposes... inasmuch as they promise something for nothing, are games of chance, and are really gambling"** (The Great Controversy 1888, "Warning

Rejected"). Engaging in these chance enterprises, even to raise money for church or charitable purposes, is an abomination to God, and believers are warned to "stand clear of all these church corruptions" (Evangelism, "The Message of Christian Stewardship").

What does the Bible mean when it says "don't bring"?

(af-124) Regarding unacceptable offerings, the sources quote Isaiah 1:13: **"Bring no more vain oblations; incense is an abomination unto Me."** This refers to offerings given by those who are engaged in sin or extortion, thinking they can buy God's favor. For instance, the money of a liquor dealer is "stained with the blood of souls," and when the church accepts such funds, God's anger is kindled against those who attempt to cover their guilt with a "cloak of liberality" (The Ministry of Healing, "Ministry to the Rich"; Temperance, "An Economic Waste"). God will not accept money obtained by violating His laws.

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here is a comprehensive response to your questions regarding diet, health, the body, and Christian lifestyle. Please note that the provided texts do not explicitly provide biblical exegesis on **Christ pronouncing all meats clean in Mark 7 (af-068), Paul's statements about unclean foods in Romans 14 or 1 Timothy 4 (af-077), Peter's vision in Acts 10 (af-083), the meaning of "every creature is good" in 1 Timothy 4:4 (af-094), Ezekiel 16 encouraging jewelry (af-133), Zechariah and the Feast of Tabernacles (af-134), or body-piercing and tattoos (af-148)**. Furthermore, they do not specifically mention modern "movies" (af-211), though they broadly address the theater. You may want to independently verify the biblical explanations for those specific texts and topics.

Here is the comprehensive information addressing your other questions:

Doesn't the Bible support the drinking of wine?

(af-046, af-129) The Bible nowhere sanctions the use of intoxicating wine as a beverage. The texts explain that when Proverbs 20:1 warns, "Wine is a mocker, strong drink is raging," it is speaking of fermented alcohol (Temperance,

"Wine in the Bible"). **The wine that Christ provided at the wedding feast of Cana, and the wine He used at the Last Supper, was the pure, unfermented juice of the grape** (The Ministry of Healing, "Intoxicating Drinks"). This fresh grape juice is the "new wine found in the cluster" which the Scriptures declare has a blessing in it (Temperance, "Wine in the Bible"). Christ's whole life was one of self-denial, and He never would have placed a temptation before humanity that would becloud reason or benumb spiritual perceptions (The Ministry of Healing, "Intoxicating Drinks").

Is vegetarianism biblical? Are Old Testament health laws only for the Jews? (af-072, af-201, af-294)Yes, a vegetarian diet is profoundly biblical. **"Grains, fruits, nuts, and vegetables constitute the diet chosen for us by our Creator"** in the Garden of Eden (The Ministry of Healing, "Selection of Food"). The eating of flesh is unnatural; God gave man no permission to eat animal food until after the global Flood, when all vegetation had been destroyed, and even then it was permitted primarily to shorten the lifespan of a rebellious race (Testimony Studies on Diet and Foods, "Flesh Foods").

Therefore, the health laws in the Old Testament were not arbitrary or intended only for the Jews. The distinction between clean and unclean animals was based upon universal sanitary principles designed for the highest physical and moral good of humanity (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Vow of the Nazarite").

Will people who eat unclean animals go to heaven? Are health laws really that important? (af-230, af-239)Health laws are incredibly important, because **"the laws of nature are the laws of God"** (Counsels on Diet and Foods, "Reasons for Reform"). Transgressing the laws of our physical being is a direct violation of the law of God, and is considered "as great a sin in the sight of Heaven as to break the Ten Commandments" (Counsels on Health, "Govern the Body"). Loving God is inextricably linked to how we treat the body He created and redeemed.

Regarding unclean meats like pork, the Bible forbids swine's flesh because swine are natural scavengers whose tissues swarm with parasites, making them wholly unfit for food

(The Ministry of Healing, "Flesh as Food"). The sources warn that **"gluttons will never enter the pearly gates,"** and those who willfully close their eyes to health reform, choosing to gratify a depraved appetite, will ultimately benumb their moral sensibilities and unfit themselves for the society of heavenly angels (Counsels on Diet and Foods, "Flesh Meats"). While the church does not make a meat diet an absolute test of fellowship for the ignorant, willful indulgence in health-destroying habits by those who know better is a salvational issue (Counsels on Diet and Foods, "Faithfulness in Health Reform").

Should Christians fast? (af-263)Yes, but biblical fasting does not always mean total starvation. The sources state that **"the true fasting which should be recommended to all, is abstinence from every stimulating kind of food, and the proper use of wholesome, simple food"**

(Counsels on Diet and Foods, "Fasting"). In cases of sickness caused by overeating, a short fast of a meal or two, or a simple fruit diet for a few days, is often the very best remedy to allow the overworked digestive organs to rest and recover (The Ministry of Healing, "Diet and Health").

Why is it wrong to dance today if people danced in the Bible? (af-110)Pleasure lovers often cite David's dancing before the ark of God to justify the fashionable modern dance, but there is no ground for such an argument.

David's dancing was an expression of "reverent joy" and joyful praise to God, which has "not the faintest resemblance to the dissipation of modern dancing"

(The Adventist Home, "How the Christian Chooses His Recreation"; Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Ark of God"). Modern dancing is associated with midnight reveling, folly, and sensual indulgence where God is completely forgotten, making it a device of Satan to weaken love for sacred things (Mind, Character and Personality, Vol. 1, "Dangers Facing Youth").

What is biblically permissible regarding entertainment and church music? (af-193, af-199)The decisive test for any Christian amusement is this: **"Any amusement in which you can engage asking the blessing of God upon it in faith will not be dangerous"** (Counsels for the Church, "Recreation"). However, any amusement that

disqualifies you for secret prayer or lessens your joy in serving God—such as theaters, ballroom dancing, and gambling—is unsafe and should be shunned (Messages to Young People, "Dancing"). Regarding church worship, as established in our previous conversation, worship should be characterized by solemnity and dignity. The use of a "bedlam of noise" and drums in church is condemned as an invention of Satan designed to shock the senses and confuse the mind (True Revival, "Beware the Counterfeits").

What does the Bible say about modesty and wedding rings? (af-228, af-280)

The Bible explicitly teaches modesty. Quoting 1 Timothy 2:9, 10 and 1 Peter 3:3-5, the sources instruct believers to adorn themselves in modest apparel, "not with broided hair, or gold, or pearls, or costly array" (Child Guidance, "The Blessings of Proper Dress"). True refinement does not seek to decorate the body for display; Christians are to shun gaudy colors and profuse ornamentation, seeking instead the imperishable ornament of a meek and quiet spirit (Child Guidance, "The Blessings of Proper Dress"). Regarding the wedding ring specifically, as established in our previous discussion, it is discouraged as an unnecessary conformity to worldly customs. Christians should not spend the Lord's money on "superfluities of dress" or "idolatry of dress," but should let their actions and pure characters testify to their marital fidelity and Christian witness (Christian Temperance and Bible Hygiene, "Christian Temperance").

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here are the answers to your questions regarding church life, gender, and ministry.

Please note that the provided texts do not explicitly address **whether women are required to cover their heads in church (af-041), whether Christians should participate in Halloween (af-279), or if the Bible teaches us to pray to Mary (af-300)**. You may want to independently verify the biblical and historical teachings on these specific subjects.

Here is the comprehensive information on the other topics covered in the texts:

Is the communion service only open to those who are members of a church and whose sins are forgiven?

(af-058)No, the church does not practice "close communion." Christ's example forbids exclusiveness at the Lord's supper. While it is true that open, unconfessed sin excludes the guilty, beyond this "none are to pass judgment" (Evangelism, "Not Close Communion"). God has not left it to human beings to decide who should present themselves on these occasions because mortals cannot read the heart or distinguish the tares from the wheat. The sources instruct: "There may come in among you those who are not in heart united with truth and holiness, but who may wish to take part in these services. Forbid them not" (Evangelism, "Not Close Communion").

Does the Bible teach that women are never to speak in church? What about women as church leaders or preachers? (af-089, af-214)

The sources strongly reject the "narrow-souled theology" which asserts that women should not speak or prophesy in church, pointing out that the prophetic promise "your daughters shall prophecy" explicitly includes women (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "Spiritual Gifts"). God has a vital work for women in the gospel ministry. They are encouraged to take their places in this crisis, as they can "do in families a work that men cannot do, a work that reaches the inner life" (Christian Service, "Women as Missionaries").

Regarding preaching and leadership, the texts note that some women "should labor in the gospel ministry," and cite examples of women who were doing "just as efficient work as the ministers," including taking the Bible and addressing the congregation (Evangelism, "Women in Public Ministry"). However, regarding the formal *ordination* of women as gospel ministers, the author was "very careful about expressing herself in any wise as to the advisability" of it, and her writings do not contain statements encouraging the official ordination of women to the public labor ordinarily expected of an ordained minister (Daughters of God, "Appendix C").

Is it always wrong to judge others? (af-177)It is always wrong to judge the *motives* or the heart of another person, as Christ is the only true standard of character. "Whoever

presumes to judge the motives of others is again usurping the prerogative of the Son of God" (Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing, "Not Judging, but Doing"). Believers are warned not to climb upon the judgment seat to become "church tinkers" who delight in picking flaws in others' dress or appearance (Historical Sketches of Foreign Missions, "Unity Among Laborers").

However, it is *not* wrong for the church to judge and discipline *open sin*. The church is commanded to "call sin by its right name" and must deal with open transgression as God directs; to do otherwise is to sanction the deeds and dishonor the Lord (The Desire of Ages, "Peace Be Unto You"; Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Public Evangelist").

What should our response be toward those who leave the church, and how can I help a friend who has quit attending? (af-179, af-298) We should respond with sympathetic, diligent effort and sincere sorrow. The sources rebuke churches that engage in "gossiping over his case" rather than putting forth diligent efforts to bring the straying member back (Pastoral Ministry, "Former Members, Inactive Members"). Instead of holding the erring off or finding fault with them, we must imitate the Good Shepherd who left the ninety-nine to pursue the one lost sheep. "Instead of finding fault with them because they are in the dark, they should light their own lamp... to dispel the darkness of those in error by the light that they bring to them" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 3, "Missionaries in the Home"). When a straying friend submits to the light, they should be received gladly, without any effort to impress upon them their exceeding sinfulness.

Can a person find favor with God by living biblically but not going to church? (af-192) While individual piety is essential, the texts explicitly warn against isolating oneself from the body of believers. "Never entertain the thought that you can be Christians and yet withdraw within yourselves. Each one is a part of the great web of humanity... Then let us not forsake the assembling of ourselves together" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 7, "Dependence on God"). We sustain a loss when we neglect associating together to encourage one another, as we are

dependent upon one another for spiritual strength and happiness (From Eternity Past, "Annual Feasts of Rejoicing"). Those who choose worldly pleasures over the privilege of being in the assembly of God's people weaken their moral power and miss the blessing of Christ's presence (Messages to Young People, "Christian Fellowship").

Does the Bible say anything about being involved in secret societies? (af-228)

Yes, the Bible strictly forbids being "unequally yoked together with unbelievers" (2 Corinthians 6:14). Uniting with secret societies—where the presence of Christ is unknown and the themes of conversation revolve around the gratification of the senses—is incompatible with the Christian life. While these societies may have some elements that appear to be good, they bring men under the deceptive power of Satan and lead away from God's standard of righteousness (Selected Messages Book 2, "Should Christians Be Members of Secret Societies?"). "No earnest Christian can prosper in such an atmosphere. The vital air of heaven is not there" (Evangelism, "Secret Societies").

What does the word "church" mean? (af-254) In the biblical context, the true church of God is defined as those who "keep God's commandments, those who live not by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7, "Chapter 19"). It is "the case which contains His jewels, the fold which encloses His flock" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, "Chapter 5"). While the "church militant" on earth is not yet the "church triumphant" and is currently composed of erring, imperfect learners with tares mingled among the wheat, God still has a distinct, organized body of people on earth who are lifting up His downtrodden law (Last Day Events, "The Church Militant Is Imperfect"; Last Day Events, "God's People Keep His Commandments").

Why are there so many denominations if they all claim to follow Jesus? (af-299) The vast multitude of differing denominations exists because "in the professedly Christian world many turn away from the plain teachings of the Bible and build up a creed from human speculations and pleasing fables" (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Tower of Babel"). If all professed followers of Christ would simply accept God's

Word as the ultimate standard, it would bring them into unity. However, "so long as human wisdom is exalted above His Holy Word, there will be divisions and dissension," resulting in a confusion of conflicting creeds that Bible prophecy designates as "Babylon" (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Tower of Babel").

Is there anything wrong with having a Christmas tree?

(af-302)As established in our previous conversation, there is no inherent sin in having a Christmas tree. "There is no particular sin in selecting a fragrant evergreen and placing it in our churches, but the sin lies in the motive which prompts to action and the use which is made of the gifts placed upon the tree" (The Adventist Home, "Christmas"). If the tree is used merely for frivolous amusement or worldly display, it is wrong. But if its boughs are "laden with the golden and silver fruit of your beneficence" and presented as an offering to God to sustain His work and help the poor, it is a highly beneficial and innocent practice (The Adventist Home, "Christmas").

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here are the answers to your questions regarding marriage, family, and personal ethics.

Please note that the provided texts do not explicitly explain **Jesus's statement about the carcass and the eagles (af-038), provide a comprehensive biblical exposition on suicide (af-171), or give specific counsel on whether to leave a church denomination that allows same-sex marriage (af-202)**. You may want to independently verify biblical explanations for those specific topics.

Here is the comprehensive information addressing your other questions:

What is the unpardonable sin? (af-022)As established in our previous conversation, the unpardonable sin (the sin against the Holy Ghost) is willfully attributing to Satan the work of the Holy Spirit. Its most common manifestation is persistently slighting Heaven's invitation to repent (Counsels to Parents, Teachers, and Students, "Failure to Study God's Word").

What does it mean to eat Christ's flesh and drink His

blood? (af-025)To eat His flesh and drink His blood means "to receive Him as a heaven-sent teacher" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, Chapter 6). It requires accepting His sacrifice and feasting on the Word of God. Those who take the Scriptures into their lives will receive eternal spiritual life and become one with the Father and the Son (The Desire of Ages, "The Crisis in Galilee"; SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, Chapter 6).

How do you put God first when you and your spouse disagree? (af-165)Spouses are urged to avoid arbitrary control and instead yield to one another, making every effort to maintain peace (The Adventist Home, "A Happy, Successful Partnership"). However, neither spouse is to surrender their conscience to the other. "God is the owner of your individuality... Your love for that which is human is to be secondary to your love for God" (The Adventist Home, "Responsibilities of Married Life"). If a spouse's demands conflict with God's claims, the believer must choose to differ, quietly but firmly giving "as his reason that he cannot sacrifice his faith or his principles" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 2, "Cause in Vermont").

Can a person be saved through his or her spouse?

(af-166)No. The texts are explicit: "You cannot save her, and she cannot save you. She has a conscience of her own by which she must be guided... She must form a character for herself, and she is accountable to God for the character she develops" (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 3, "Religion in the Family").

What if you have a desire to get married but God's providence calls on you to be single? (af-170)Remaining single for the Lord is a commendable path. The apostle Paul chose to remain single so he could be wholly the Lord's, and recommended it to others. The sources point out that choosing to remain single is a wise course for those who wish to make a sure thing of "avoiding the cares, trials, and bitter anguish so frequent in the experiences of those who choose the married life," unless there is unquestionable evidence that marriage would make their path to heaven more sure (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Appeal to Ministers").

What does the Bible say about divorce? (af-185)The

Bible teaches that marriage is a lifelong covenant. Jesus pointed back to Eden, showing that God intended marriage to be indissoluble. "There could be no dissolution of the marriage tie, except for unfaithfulness to the marriage vow" (Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing, "The Spirituality of the Law"). Adultery is the *only* sin that places a husband or wife in a position where they are free from the marriage vow in the sight of God (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Grounds for Divorce").

What does the Bible say about dating? (af-197) The Bible and the sources strongly warn against "blind love" and "lovesick sentimentalism" in courtship. Deceptive courtships carried on without the consent of parents are a violation of the commandment "Thou shalt not steal" (Fundamentals of Christian Education, "Courtship and Marriage"). The rule for a Christian couple is strict purity: "Not one word should be spoken, not one action performed, that you would not be willing the holy angels should look upon and register in the books above" (The Adventist Home, "Common Courtship Practices").

Should we only support the innocent party in a married couple getting a divorce? (af-272) While the innocent party in a divorce for adultery has a biblical right to be free, the church is commanded to have "deep, earnest, soul-touching sympathy and love for the tempted and the erring" (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Understanding Others"). If the erring spouse repents and confesses, the church must not drive them to despair or treat them as outcasts; rather, they should be restored in the spirit of meekness (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Respect for Unbiblical Marriages").

How do Christians deal with meddlesome parents and in-laws without dishonoring them? (af-274) While children must always show respect, "there is a sacred circle around every family which should be preserved. No other one has any right in that sacred circle" (The Adventist Home, "A Sacred Circle"). The texts strictly counsel that "friends and acquaintances we may have, but in the homelife they are not to meddle" (Mind, Character, and Personality, Vol. 1, "Security in the Home").

Does God forbid reconciliation if one spouse ran off with another person but later wants to return home?

(af-276)No, God does not forbid reconciliation. If the erring spouse truly repents, reconciliation and forgiveness can bring healing. The texts suggest that "time, and labor, and prayer, and patience, and faith, and a godly life, might work a reform" in an unfaithful spouse, though the innocent party must weigh if their own health or safety is at risk in attempting it (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Appeal to Ministers").

Does God expect me to live with a physically abusive spouse? (af-278)God does not expect a spouse to remain if their life is endangered. While the marriage vow is sacred, if a spouse utterly refuses to keep the vow and becomes an abusive tool of Satan, the innocent party "is under no obligations to keep one by his side who will only torture his soul" (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Separation"). Furthermore, a spouse's moral right to depart is affirmed if "her health and life be not greatly endangered in so remaining"—meaning that if life is endangered, separation is justified (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Appeal to Ministers").

Should we still honor our parents if they are abusive?

(af-286)The command to honor parents does not cease when a parent is disagreeable or unjust. "Even were the mother an unbeliever and disagreeable, it would not release the child from the obligation that God has placed upon him to care for his parent" in their old age or times of need (The Retirement Years, "Obligation of Children to Aged Parents"). However, honoring them does not mean yielding one's conscience to them or remaining in a situation that ruins one's own soul or marriage.

Is homosexuality a sin? (af-303)Yes, it is explicitly condemned as a great sin. The sources refer to it as "Sodomitish impurity" and state that "those who do not repent of and forsake all uncleanness will fall with the wicked" (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Homosexuality"). Engaging in homosexual practices is described as a "polluting practice" and a "terrible insult to Jesus Christ" (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Child Abuse").

Does the Bible really speak against sex before

marriage? (af-304)Yes, the Bible strictly forbids it.

Believers are commanded to "abstain from fornication" and to possess their vessels in sanctification and honor (A Call to Stand Apart, "Relationships"). Spending the night in one another's arms before marriage is condemned as a "reproach to the cause of God," a violation of the seventh commandment, and a behavior that gives occasion for enemies to judge Christians as loose in morals (Testimonies on Sexual Behavior, Adultery, and Divorce, "Petting and Premarital Sex").

Does the Bible speak against interracial marriages?

(af-305)The sources emphasize that God "makes no difference between white and black" and firmly upholds the "equality of all races and the brotherhood of mankind" (Selected Messages Book 2, "The Brotherhood of Mankind"). Because of this equality, the counsel given against interracial marriage is "not an issue of racial inequality; but essentially a question of advisability or inadvisability stemming from circumstances and conditions that could result in controversy, confusion and bitterness" (Selected Messages Book 2, "Counsel Regarding Intermarriage"). To prevent this predictable social strife and the resulting hardships on the family, the advice given is that such marriages should not be encouraged.

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here is a comprehensive response to your questions regarding salvation, faith, works, and the Christian life:

Becoming a Christian: Steps, Choice, and Surrender

(af-107, af-150, af-153, af-178, af-266)The basic steps to becoming a Christian are genuine repentance of sin, faith in the merits of Jesus Christ, and baptism, which represent the new birth (*The Youth's Instructor*, "February 1, 1874"). Jesus declared that unless a person is "born again," they cannot see the kingdom of God. This is necessary because by nature, the human heart is evil and alienated from God; the very fountain of the heart must be completely purified and transformed by the Holy Spirit before the life can become pure (*The Desire of Ages*, "Nicodemus"; *The Great*

Controversy, "Modern Revivals").

If you struggle to surrender or do not feel like doing what God wants, you must understand the true force of the will. The will is the governing power of human nature, representing the power of choice. While you cannot change your own heart or force your own affections, you *can* choose to serve Him. You surrender by giving God your will; He will then work in you "to will and to do according to His good pleasure" (*Steps to Christ, "Consecration")*.

The Atonement, Forgiveness, and Grace (af-002, af-155, af-264, af-271, af-273) Salvation is entirely a free gift of God, and it is impossible to earn it by human merit (*Selected Messages Book 3, "Emphasis on Salvation Theme—1890-1908"*). One man's death could pay the penalty for all humanity because Christ's position with His Father is one of absolute equality, which enabled Him to become a sufficient sin-offering for the whole world and magnify the broken law (*SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7, Chapter 2*). Therefore, Christ made a full, complete ransom on Calvary, and you do not need to do anything to add to or "merit" His atonement (*Faith and Works, "Appropriating the Righteousness of Christ"*).

When we come to Christ, He grants "remission of sins that are past" (*The Great Controversy, "Modern Revivals"*). The gospel does not offer blanket pre-forgiveness for future intentional rebellion. However, if a believer stumbles and falls again, Jesus does not immediately forsake them. The sources assure us that if, through manifold temptations, we are surprised or deceived into sin, "He does not turn from us and leave us to perish... we have an advocate with the Father" (*SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 7, Chapter 2*).

Predestination, Sincerity, and Eternal Security (af-064, af-186, af-243) God has not arbitrarily predestined certain people to be saved and others to be lost. The doctrine of unconditional election is contrary to Scripture; instead, God's election is based on the condition of practice and obedience (*SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, Chapter 1*). Everyone is elected who will exercise faith and work out their own salvation (*Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Law and the Covenants"*).

Consequently, "once saved, always saved" is a false doctrine.

A person may be saved today, but if they fail to grow daily in Christ and become self-confident, they can fall away and be lost tomorrow (*True Revival*, "Saved Only 'In Christ'"). Furthermore, sincerity and zeal alone are not enough for salvation. Sincerity in believing a lie or following a false religion will not save a soul; we must seek and obey the truth (*Selected Messages Book 2*, "Our Safety Against Delusions").

Faith, Works, and the Law (af-190, af-245, af-261) When it comes to righteousness by faith, humanity does have a role: we must cooperate with God. Faith and works are like two oars of a boat; God does nothing for man without his cooperation, yet man's efforts alone are worthless without the Holy Spirit (*True Revival*, "The Balance in Faith and Works").

It is not legalistic to follow Christian rules of conduct. A "legal religion" is attempting to earn salvation by your own works, which is a loveless, Christless endeavor (*A Call to Stand Apart*, "When Doing Everything Right Isn't Enough"). In contrast, true faith inevitably leads to perfect conformity to God's law, because obedience is the natural fruit of saving faith (*Steps to Christ*, "The Test of Discipleship"). To walk after the Spirit and not the flesh means that through the new birth, the heart is brought into harmony with God's law, and "the righteousness of the law" is fulfilled in our daily lives (*The Great Controversy*, "Modern Revivals").

Difficult Commands and Christian Lifestyle (af-149, af-259, af-262) When commands seem unreasonable or too hard, believers should remember that God never uses His power to oppress, nor does He require more than man is able to perform (*SDA Bible Commentary*, vol. 2, Chapter 23). In every command God gives, there is a positive promise underlying it (*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, "The Spirituality of the Law"). Simply put, "His biddings are enablings" (*Messages to Young People*, "Perfecting Character").

We benefit immensely from keeping these commands. Obedience to God's law is essential not only for our salvation but for our own happiness, physical health, and the well-being of all those connected to us (*True Revival*, "God Has Rules Too").

To adopt a Christian lifestyle without appearing judgmental or legalistic, you must be filled with the love of Christ. The effort to earn salvation by works causes men to become "self-centered judges and petty spies" who harshly criticize others (*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, "Not Judging, but Doing"). A genuine Christian is sympathetic, humble, and lovable. In fact, "the strongest argument in favor of the gospel is a loving and lovable Christian" (*Last-Day Events*, "Latter Rain").

Thoughts and Confession (af-191, af-196)A thought can indeed be a sin. The law of God is exceedingly broad, and the believer must wage a constant struggle against the "evil imaginings of the mind," bringing every thought into captivity to Christ (*SDA Bible Commentary*, vol. 3, Chapter 1; *A New Life*, "It's Still a Fight").

Regarding confession, you are not required to confess all your sins to your Christian brethren. Secret sins should be confessed to God alone. However, true confession must be specific: if you have wronged a neighbor or a fellow believer, you must acknowledge your fault directly to the individuals who have suffered injury and make restitution (*Steps to Christ*, "Confession"; *Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 5, "Erroneous Ideas of Confession").

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here are the answers to your questions regarding Bible interpretation and hermeneutics.

Please note that the provided texts do not explicitly provide biblical exegesis regarding **Paul's "thorn in the flesh" (af-090), the prohibition of boiling a baby goat in its mother's milk (af-122), whether Paul teaches us to "hold the traditions" of the church (af-066), or if Jesus purposely used parables to frustrate people who sought to be converted (af-207)**. You may want to independently verify the biblical context for those specific questions.

Here is the comprehensive information addressing the other topics in your query:

How could a loving God order men, women, and children to be killed? (af-003)God is incredibly long-

suffering, but He is also perfectly just. Regarding the Old Testament judgments (like the Canaanites or the Flood), God has unlimited control over all the works of His hands, and **"there is no injustice in His character"** (Selected Messages Book 2, "On the Military Question"). God spared the Amorites for four hundred years to give them unmistakable evidence of the true God, waiting to execute judgment until "the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet full" (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 1, Chapter 15). Only when their guilt reached its absolute limit and they clung to brutal idolatry—such as passing their children through the fire (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 1, Chapter 18)—were they destroyed. **Unconditional pardon for such high-handed rebellion would be weakness, not benevolence,** and would fill the unfallen universe with consternation (The Spirit of Prophecy, vol. 4, "First Great Deception"). Ultimately, the destruction of the wicked is an act of mercy to the universe to prevent sin from being perpetuated eternally.

What does it mean that Christ preached to "spirits" that were in prison? (af-005) This text (1 Peter 3:18-21) does not teach that Christ descended to an underworld after His crucifixion. Rather, it refers to the antediluvian world before the Flood. **God granted the people of Noah's day "one hundred and twenty years of probation, and during that time preached to them through Methuselah, Noah, and many others of His servants"** (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 1, Chapter 3). The "spirits in prison" were the living people before the Flood whose minds were imprisoned by sin, to whom Christ's Spirit appealed through Noah's warnings.

Does the Bible talk about dinosaurs? (af-021) While the modern word "dinosaur" is not used, the sources affirm that before the Flood, **"the development of vegetable and animal life was immeasurably superior to that which has since been known"** (Education, "Science and the Bible"). God so ordered that **"men, beasts, and trees, many times larger than those now upon the earth... should be buried in the earth at the time of the flood"** (Spiritual Gifts, vol. 3, "Disguised Infidelity"). The massive fossils found in the earth today are preserved by God to

serve as evidence to later generations that the old world perished by a global flood.

How was it that Moses and Elijah appeared with Christ if the dead do not go to heaven? (af-048)

Their appearance on the Mount of Transfiguration perfectly aligns with the biblical doctrine of the state of the dead. **Elijah was translated to heaven without ever seeing death,** and **Moses died but was literally resurrected from the grave by Christ** (The Truth About Angels, "Angels From Sinai to the Taking of Jericho"). Therefore, they did not appear as disembodied ghosts, but as real, physical beings from heaven, representing the future kingdom of glory in miniature (The Desire of Ages, "The Transfiguration").

Did God give Noah permission to eat "every moving thing" for food? (af-049)

No, God did not give Noah permission to eat *every* moving thing unconditionally. Because all vegetation had been destroyed by the Flood, **"the Lord in their necessity gave Noah permission to eat of the clean animals which he had taken with him into the ark"** (Counsels on Diet and Foods, "Flesh Meats"). The consumption of unclean animals was never permitted by the Creator.

Does the second commandment forbid making any kind of religious artwork? (af-052)

No, the second commandment does not forbid making any kind of artwork or picture. While some extremists have condemned all pictures as idolatry, the sources clarify that **"the second commandment prohibits image worship; but God himself employed pictures and symbols to represent to his prophets lessons which he would have them give to the people"** (Historical Sketches of Foreign Missions, "Address at Orebro"). Because God appeals to the human understanding through the sense of sight, creating visual representations for instruction is not a sin; the sin lies in bowing down to serve them.

Does the apostle Paul teach that all Jews will be saved in God's kingdom? (af-078)

Paul does not teach an unconditional salvation for every ethnic Jewish person. God is no respecter of persons; **He is "abundantly able to transform the hearts of Jew and Gentile alike"** (From Trials to Triumph, "Letters Paul Wrote From Rome"). While

God anciently chose the Israelites as a special people, it was to make them light-bearers to all nations. Because the nation failed this purpose, God's true Israel is now made up of all who yield themselves to Him, regardless of ethnicity.

There is no arbitrary election where anyone is excluded or guaranteed salvation merely by lineage; every soul is elected who chooses to obey God (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 6, Chapter 11).

Did Moses actually write the Ten Commandments?

(af-121)No, Moses did not compose or write the Ten Commandments. **"The Ten Commandments were spoken by God Himself, and were written by His own hand.**

They are of divine, and not of human composition"

(The Great Controversy, "Introduction"). God wrote them with His own holy finger upon the two tables of stone (Christian Experience and Teachings of Ellen G. White, "A Firm Platform").

What will happen to people who have never heard

about Jesus? (af-159)People who have never heard the gospel will be judged according to the light they had. **"Not one suffers the wrath of God until the truth has been brought home to his mind and conscience and has been rejected"** (From Here to Forever, "Our Only

Safeguard"). Among the heathen are those who worship God ignorantly; because they heard God's voice speaking to them in nature and cherished a spirit of kindness, their works evidence that the Holy Spirit touched their hearts, and they will be accepted in heaven (Heaven, "Who Will Be There?").

How can you know for sure which religion is the right

one? (af-187)The Bible gives a clear standard to test all religions, teachers, and miracles: **"To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them"** (The Great

Controversy, "The Scriptures a Safeguard"). We are not to judge by emotional experiences or impressive miracles, but by their fruits. The true religion will lead its followers to reverence God and manifest their love by strict obedience to all of His commandments (Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing, "Not Judging, but Doing").

Should Christians observe any of the Jewish festivals?

(af-203)No, Christians are not required to observe the

Jewish festivals. The ceremonial system was made up of symbols pointing forward to Christ's sacrifice. **"This ritual law, with its sacrifices and ordinances, was to be performed by the Hebrews until type met antitype in the death of Christ"** (Patriarchs and Prophets, "The Law and the Covenants"). When Jesus died on the cross, the entire system of ceremonial types, shadows, and festivals ceased and was nailed to His cross.

What is the nature of the Trinity? (af-210) The sources strongly affirm the existence of "three living persons of the heavenly trio": God the Father, Christ the Son, and the Holy Spirit (Evangelism, "Misrepresentations of the Godhead"). However, **we are sternly warned against philosophizing or speculating about the exact nature of God's being.** "No human mind can comprehend God. Let not finite man attempt to interpret Him. Let none indulge in speculation regarding His nature. Here silence is eloquence. The Omniscient One is above discussion" (The Ministry of Healing, "Danger in Speculative Knowledge").

Based on the provided sources and our conversation history, here is a comprehensive response to your questions regarding Christian conduct, ethics, and practical living. Please note that the provided texts do not explicitly provide biblical exegesis regarding **1 John 5:16 and sins leading to death versus those that do not (af-142)**, a specific command that **we must only call God "Jehovah" (af-198)**, or **where Cain found his wife (af-289)**. You may want to independently verify the biblical explanations for those specific topics.

Here is the comprehensive information addressing your other questions:

Does the apostle Paul teach that if we think something is okay, then it's okay? (af-132) No, Paul does not teach this, and his own life proves the danger of that idea. The sources state: **"Men may be conscientiously wrong as well as conscientiously right. Paul did not believe in Jesus of Nazareth, and he hunted the Christians from city to city, verily believing that he was doing service to God"** (Mind, Character, and Personality, Vol. 1,

"Conscience"). A person cannot practice anything they please simply because they conscientiously believe it to be right. Conscience is not to take the place of "Thus saith the Lord"; it must be continually enlightened by the Word of God, otherwise it will deceive us.

How can I really know truth, and how do I differentiate between opinion and fact or discern cults? (af-157, af-215)

To really know the truth, you must be willing to obey it. **"In order to arrive at truth, we must have a sincere desire to know the truth and a willingness of heart to obey it"** (Steps to Christ, "What to Do with Doubt"). If you perform every duty that God has already made plain to your understanding, you will be enabled to understand the things you currently doubt. When discerning between Bible-believing churches and false movements, the standard is clear: **"To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them"** (The Great Controversy, "The Scriptures a Safeguard"). Off-the-wall cults and fanatical movements typically rely on "man-made tests," sensationalism, and human philosophy rather than the plain Word of God (Evangelism, "False Tests and Man-Made Standards").

How can I share the truth about God with my friends? (af-154)

The most powerful way to share the truth is through your daily life. **"The best way in which you can recommend the truth is, not by argument, not by talk, but by living it daily, by leading a consistent, modest, humble life as a disciple of Christ"** (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 3, "Opposing Relatives"). When you do speak, avoid harshness and debates. "Dwell not on the negative points of questions that arise, but gather to your minds affirmative truths" (Evangelism, "Debate"). Let the Word of God do the cutting, and always represent Christ in His meekness and love.

Why does God sometimes seem silent when we need Him most? (af-175)

God sometimes delays His answers to test our faith and our hearts. **"God does not always answer our prayers the first time we call upon Him; for should He do this, we might take it for granted that we had a right to all the blessings and favors He bestowed upon us"** (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 2, "Chapter 18"). A

delay gives us the opportunity to search our hearts to see if we are harboring any sin, and to realize our utter dependence upon Him. In the darkest days, we must trust Him and remember Christ's words: "What I do thou knowest not now; but thou shalt know hereafter" (Help in Daily Living, "Living With Others").

How can I make my faith in God stronger?

(af-208)Faith grows through exercise and focus. **"You have to talk faith, you have to live faith, you have to act faith, that you may have an increase of faith"** (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 5, "Chapter 17"). Conversely, the more you talk about your doubts and discouragements, the darker everything will grow. You must purposefully close the windows of the soul earthward and open them heavenward, trusting God's promises regardless of how you feel (The Voice in Speech and Song, "Faith a Topic of Conversation").

What are some biblical tips to dealing with personal anger? (af-213)The sources highly recommend the "eloquence of silence." When you feel angry, **"do not speak a word until you have sent up your petition to the God of heaven. If you will always do this, you will soon overcome your hasty temper"** (Historical Sketches of Foreign Missions, "Practical Addresses"). When one gives place to an angry spirit, they become as intoxicated as a man drinking liquor. You must refuse to retaliate; "anger met with silence, in a tender, forbearing spirit, quickly dies away" (Gospel Workers, "Forbearance Under Wrong").

What are the greatest dangers for Christians today?

(af-270)The greatest danger to the church does not come from outside persecution, but from within. **"The influence most to be feared by the church is not that of open opposers, infidels, and blasphemers, but of inconsistent professors of Christ"** (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 3, "Opposing Relatives"). Spiritual coldness, worldly conformity, and the spirit of intense selfishness and faultfinding are the evils that grieve the Holy Spirit and bring the greatest weakness upon God's people.

How can I become wise like Solomon? (af-291)Solomon gained his wisdom because, in his youth, he **"looked to God for guidance and trusted in Him, and God chose for him and gave him wisdom that astonished the world"**

(Testimonies for the Church, vol. 2, "Duties of the Husband and the Wife"). However, Solomon's life is also a warning. When he stopped relying on God and yielded his principles to lustful passions, his wisdom departed, and he was ruined. True wisdom is found only through a continual, humble dependence on the counsels of God (SDA Bible Commentary, vol. 2, "Chapter 11").

What does the Bible say about low self-esteem, and how can I live with more confidence? (af-292,

af-293)You gain true self-esteem by looking at the cross.

"Calvary testifies to you of the value of your soul" (A Call to Stand Apart, "Relationships"). To live with confidence, you must stop looking within yourself for validation, because you will only find things to discourage you. **"Many make a serious mistake in their religious life by keeping the attention fixed upon their feelings... We are not to look within for evidence of our acceptance with God. Our only hope is in 'looking unto Jesus'"** (Testimonies for the Church, vol. 5, "Looking Unto Jesus").

What can a Christian do when feeling deep loneliness?

(af-295)When you feel lonely, you must turn to the ultimate Companion. **"You may never be lonesome, never feel that you are alone, if you will take Jesus as your Companion and your Everlasting Friend"** (Mind, Character, and Personality, Vol. 2, "Emotional Needs"). The sources remind believers that in the darkest times, when earthly friends fail or disappoint, Jesus, the great Burden Bearer, says, "Come unto Me, and I will give you rest" (The Ministry of Healing, "A Higher Experience").
